US critiques say that they are sort of our bosses. Whatever they'll say we have to follow. If you are a great power for a long time, you develop an arrogance. I don't think there is anybody in the world who thinks that India will be following the US. Even the US doesn't think. Sayyad Akbarin was the official spokesperson of India's ministry of external affairs. China is a major challenge for us. They do not want anybody else in Asia. He has spent more than 30 years strengthening India's global diplomacy. China sees India's rise as a challenge. He breaks down whether the US and China have been influencing India's decisions. No country which is on top wants others to rise. India will rise irrespective of whether US says the curve is not going to change. How India's neighbors are being used against it. China has become a major player in our neighborhood. He cannot compete today with China because they have deeper pockets and you need to pay attention to what he's saying right now. I served in Pakistan during very tumultous time. Their state thinks their society cannot flourish if they see a flourishing India. And according to him, India is walking on a very thin line between global pressures and unpredictable world leaders. Iran is the gateway for us to central Asia and the rest of West Asia. So if we give up on Iran then you are reducing your strategic space and why India is not taking any side in the current war. In 1980s our economy was linked with the globe about 15%. Today it's 50%. We have to be more guarded and cautious and most importantly where does India stand today globally and what are the things that can become reasons for India's downfall our challenges have become much more than normal countries who have grown in the past their challenges were before we start today's podcast we are on a mission to make an Indian podcast reach a global level And as of today, we need 20.8 million subscribers to get there. So if you have found anything valuable from this channel, please subscribe. It's free. It takes less than a minute, but it means a lot to us and will take us closer to a dream. And in return, we promise to keep bringing you the most valuable conversations every single time. And to listen to the audio experience of this episode, please follow us on Spotify. from the very beginning actually because I think a lot of people won't even know that what does a diplomat actually like what what's your job like explain us in the most simple way if somebody's watching you for the first time who are you and what is a job of a diplomat so a diplomat is by conventional views saying that he goes out to life for his country. Okay. But he goes out to lie for his country. Yes, that is the traditional view of a diplomat. He right or wrong my country. However, the world has changed since then. So, a diplomat is now a multitasker. What he or she does is the general feeling is that you know a diplomat goes he's protocol and alcohol is what the diplomats do. But that's not what they do. It's not so glamorous. Our life is to be helpful to a country's interest outside India and increasingly what is happening is uh India's interests are growing and therefore the role of the diplomats has grown when I started India's interests were not that interlin with the world today it's linked in every way so I work for example in Saudi Arabia now in Saudi Arabia there are something like 2 and a half million Indians So you are like a district collector for them. You are like a lawyer for them. You are like a commercial assistant for them. You are trying to help the Indian community. That's one part of the role. Another part of the role is to promote Indian trade. So Indian businessmen come uh Indian manufacturers come. So to help them that's another part of a role. A third part of the role is increasingly India's security concerns are growing. So uh can we have exchange of security information? So that's a third part of a role. Okay. A fourth part of the role is remittances economic opportunities in India. So ask the country's host country to try and look at India for investment. So it is about jobs, it is about um energy like you can see now. It is about um uh opportunities to study. So a diplomat is a multitasker who is India's representative outside India representing India in any and every aspect. Okay.

And do you represent the host country wherever you have been posted that country in India as well? No. Uh that their diplomats will do. Okay. But but because you are there would you not act as like a channel partner between both of these countries? Absolutely right. We would do that because for many people that's a black hole. If you are in some country where there is only you know about its loss only you know about its benefits what are the opportunities there so you are also an informal channel or a link between that country and India and you promote that because by doing that you're also doing your first job okay so 1986 what was a role of a diplomat 1 2 3 four points tell me and what is the role of diplomat today maybe five 10 points true so I would know like how the role has expanded. So in 1986 my first posting was to Egypt. M Egypt there were about only 500 Indians. Okay. So I didn't have to do very much counselor related work. It used to be less than 40 hours. I think it was 32 hours a week. So my job was from 8:00 to 2:00 and after that I would come back home. People say oh that's also too much because the pace of life was different. Um so what did I do? Uh the most important product in Egypt was Amitab Bachan and we used to take out piggybacking on him. We used to take out a magazine called uh the voice of India in Arabic. And every magazine had Amitab Bachan's picture in it. So it was sold out. We would keep it in our car and if a policeman comes and says you're wrong talking they will say oh Hindi Amitab Bachan that's it our day was made the policeman would not even bother about us. So we were actually small representatives of Amitab Bachan in Egypt rather than anything else. What else did we do? Yes. So we we were told to learn how to mix with high society. So I started learning golf. M in the evenings. So that was a skill that came in handy much later in life but at that time it was good. The other thing that we did was uh because we were required to study a language and my language was Arabic. So I was among the few officers who could understand Arabic who could read the newspapers and interpret it for the senior officers. So that was one way of interpreting the world uh or that country to India. Finally um it was also as a young officer I was also mixing with younger people. So we had a better idea of close societies that how different segments of society. So it was largely a observing job. It was largely a job of uh assessing what that country was and the relationship there was no major challenge. So the relationship was going strong. Got it. But would you be responsible for helping India's influence grow in that region? Yes. Through Amitab Bachan. Okay. So soft power. Yes. Soft power. We would use that. And I remember uh Amitab Bachan was I'll give you an example of the film. So I went there. The film MD was running. And they had found that these Indian films are coming and the Egyptian film industry was totally being undermined because Amitab Bachan was by far the superpower there. So they said we they came up with a legislation which said that uh you know no theater can run a uh Indian film no A-class theater can run an Indian film for more than 6 months because Egyptian films were not working. Um so we started asking how to do it and then the owner of the uh theaters came to us and said look I'm going to do something which is unusual in Egypt but we're going to do it and he said I'm going to classify myself as a B-class theater just so that I don't fall into the categorization of that and then mud ran for all the time I was there in Egypt for 3 years. Wow. So you can see how soft power how working with entrepreneurs helps in promoting and I much later I think Amitab Bachan went there sometime in 2000 and I was told that the road from the airport to his hotel was blocked. They had to fly him through a helicopter. Wow. So these are all unwritten stories of India's soft power and we all played small roles in expanding that. Right. Interesting. So that was at that time observing promoting India soft power and that's it like there were like two and learning some skills new skills interpreting what the Arab nation Egypt thought about India and all the interest fair also how they were are they moving towards a democracy are they

falling etc it's largely political okay largely political and what would be a role of a diplomat today give me like 10 12 points Right. The diplomat today is become a jack of all. So let's start with the Indian community. In every part of India, the world you find a huge Indian community. Um I when I was in Saudi Arabia for example, there were 200,000 Indians. Today there are more than 2 million 2 million Indians. So their needs have expanded exponentially. So your work relating to the Indian community has expanded from virtually less than 5% to maybe about 25% or 30%. That's one big chunk. Another chunk is that India's role has expanded. So all of the countries where you are they want to understand India better. They want to look at opportunities of investment which was not the case before because we were a closed economy in 1980s. U nobody would want it. we would say no we don't know we are self-sufficient etc today bringing in even if it is 10% of investment from outside adds to India's economic growth so economic investment is a big issue another one is remittances today India is the world's largest beneficiary of remittances 125 billion to 130 billion and so you need to have smooth mechanisms of trans uh transfer of remittances cheaper interest rates uh lesser cost for transmission etc. So there's another that element. A fourth element I would say is um everybody is interested in what signals India is giving because we are today a big country, a country which thinks and acts. So they also want to take uh signals from it. When I was at the UN for example, a lot of countries would come informally and ask me can you tell me how you are voting because I have to send back to my capital. This is my assessment. This is what India is doing. we have similarly placed maybe va. So it has an influence which is not said outside but it has an influence. So that's another uh way of keeping the local people informed about the developments in India. You said it's also informing local people. When you mean local the local Indians or no the local country so if I'm in Saudi Arabia the Indians I will inform about their welfare etc. I will also inform about benefits in India because NRIs invest also but I am looking for the elite in that country who have surplus for example in Saudi Arabia it's a surplus capital surplus country if it can invest in some sectors I'd be happy to do that so I would like to inform them also a lot of people are now interested in what is India doing on this what is India doing on that how are India's for example our digital UPI it's a miracle that nobody believed and I myself when I was young if somebody had told me this I would said no this is not at all I mean what we have seen in the last 10 15 years it's a miracle because we didn't even know who is an Indian and not an Indian before and I remember in the days when I was young diplomat people also didn't know what was uh uh this and if somebody had told me every Indian will have a phone I would laugh and say are you mad forget about a digital identity so things like that I mean informing the local people and instigating them to think that they could be a opportunity for them to gain from. Got it. But you said they also ask who are you voting? What is India doing? Right? Like why would somebody in Saudi Arabia or in America or in I don't know whichever country Egypt, right? They would care about who are you voting for? So everybody is interested in being on the winning side. Everybody. So they want to deal with certain politics. They want to know. They want to know. Not voting. I didn't mean voting in the sense of election in India. Okay. What I meant was which side are you supporting in terms of a international issue? So for example, if there is a a dispute uh between Cuba and US, where are you thinking it will? Because they want to gain from our knowledge also. Ultimately diplomats gather information. So it's a form of information but it's our job to explain our country outside India also to a larger audience and I'm certain after this you'll have lots of foreign diplomats wanting and coming to engage with you because your reach is exponential compared to what they what they would be meeting in diplomatic functions etc because it's important for a larger amount of people to understand what a country is doing. Mhm. And

you were saying in the beginning the final job of a diplomat is Yes. And a final job of a diplomat is to which sometimes said is the only job but is to represent India in all its traditions. So India is not a ordinary state. It's a if I may say so it's like a civilization state. Uh it's a state which has embedded values for hundreds and thousands of years. uh and so if we take our values I remember when I went to the UN we celebrated Diwali uh and the first time there was on the UN happy Diwali now of course you can say why are you wasting money on that but my idea was that's my calling card that India has now arrived that the whole world understands what is Diwali and it sure all these things don't come free and we need to acknowledge that but in the cost benefit it gains much more If people understand what is this because we can link it with for example the UN values of victory of uh good over evil. This is what the UN does. This is what our traditions say. So it's not a bad idea to inculcate these beliefs or promote these thinking that we are a tradition which has been interlocked with global good for centuries. It's not new. Why is it important for the world to know what Diwali is at any cost? Like why would they care and why why do we as Indians care that the world should celebrate our festival? Because they're not going to celebrate a sure right but just knowing how does it matter. So it matters because India in the next I'm looking at the next 50 years we all understand the benefit uh the importance of Christmas for example globally that this is a season where XY Z and this is what you do about it. If India is now one sixth of the world, if Indians are now reaching out all over the world, it it helps for those people to understand that these are not a threat to them. Their civilizational heritage is something that can coexist with us. Their values are something which are not very different from theirs because what we are promoting are global values and if India can do that it will help you in a softer manner proceed and of course with softness comes the hard power also that once you have understanding then you may want to buy weapons from India also it's uh you see working together is a process and it cannot come in a day So the better you understand people, the better you understand uh civilization, the more possibility that you'll engage with them. Interesting. So you're saying that the idea of promoting festivals in the world is bec like the merit in this idea is because we will be able to become better friends with the people who are living outside India and be able to make them realize that we are not a threat. So we can just we celebrate Christmas, you celebrate this, we celebrate this, you celebrate this and like just together coexist. So nobody's a threat to nobody. And if we start doing that from a kids level, probably in the future they'll start treating India in a much better light than to see us as threat. That's one thing. The other is that the better you understand they may get attracted to that. say hey our festivals are actually so much of color and realry etc. It's a good tourist promotion also. Yeah. I don't see it contradicting a longerterm goal and a immediate goal also. True. True. Okay. Then one one big job of a diplomat right crisis management. When what do you do when the crisis happens like let's say there's a big crisis which happened between two countries who do you call? What's the first thing? Do you guys know in advance that this is going to happen? Um yeah, we will have an understanding that may happen but it never works out. I remember as a young diplomat I was on the border between Kuwait and Saudi Arabia and nobody knew that this was going to happen. We were just on a counselor tour helping Indians and it happened. So we were told to go to the border and the ordinary Indian you will understand that for the ordinary Indian the Indian flag is the biggest symbol. He doesn't understand some people cannot even we I cannot even speak to them in the language but they see the Indian flag they okay this is the Indian haven for them so I remember of thousands of Indians running away from Kuwait and coming when Saddam Hussein invaded Kuwait and so we have a now increasingly we now have a standard crisis management protocol but those days we didn't have so we started from

scratch so what was the thing there was a challenge at that time that how do you bring and we all got them to safety in Saudi Arabia. Uh this was in ' 89 etc. Um but how do you fly them out? At that time the Indian government I think Mr. Gujaral was there and the uh was the foreign minister and then they said you must take a undertaking from everybody that he will pay this money when he comes back to India. Look at us now today crisis in every part of the world. we are able to bring back our nationals. No questions asked. Some people misuse it. I'm not question saying that. But no questions asked there. And it was so difficult in those uh uh uh sequences of protocol management to get people to write. They would say no, I'm not going to write. Why am I going to pay? Because the air ticket from say Kuwait to India or Saudi Arabia or Jordan to India was about 20,000 rupees or 25,000 which is a large sum there. And they had already lost their money. they had lost their bank and I think one of the things that they did then was they decided that we should have a fund which will cater to those and today that fund is doing very well it was started during the first Gulf War and it's now continuing so there is a protocol of how to assist Indians how to work out but today our resources have become much better we can do by ship we can do by air we can we have good contacts and embassies everywhere so you move them by land and send them back you can see Now those who are stuck in Iran are coming back from Azharbaijan, from Armenia, some who are crossing elsewhere and coming. So our resources have increased, our ability to engage with governments have increased. So it's it's much easier now than in the past where communications was difficult. We didn't know what the government will agree or not agree and you are left there small outpost trying to do the best in a difficult situation. But what do you do now? Let's say if somebody's posted, if somebody was posted in Iran and the crisis happened, you know that they have launched epic fury. They're bombing Iran. Our Indian citizens who will be in the country in the city, they are at risk and it's crisis, right? Let's say all of a sudden it happened, nobody knew and the Indian embassy there or a diplomat there. It's his or her responsibility now to take out thousands of Indians. What would you do? Like what is the first protocol for diplomat to do? Yeah. So first thing is whenever there is uncertainty we issue advisory saying that please leave the country and please do not come to the country. Answer is it is essential. So business and all you don't need to come now given the situation because even before this happened there was uncertainty in that region. So number one is to advise saying that please leave on your own um and where you need assistance we will talk to the authorities to allow you to leave like if right bombing from the air how would somebody Sure. Now what I meant and leave fair what I meant was before the crisis because you see the crisis coming you first take all commercial flights and leave because it's possible at that stage now some will leave some will not leave and it's normal people want to stay back and say oh you know government says like this it's not real etc it's normal for people we can manage something people will say that I've done it here there etc it's possible so What we generally do is we work out with the host country. You cannot do anything without the host country being involved. So if it's in Iran, the government of Iran and they are generally very cooperative. Any host is very cooperative because it doesn't want foreigners to get stuck in their territory. So they will say all right we will arrange for them to leave through this exit. You arrange for them to go there. So my responsibility or that embassy's responsibility is to take them by bus or by car or by whatever train whatever else to that point where they can exit. So sometimes people don't have money sometimes they don't want to spend money. So that's spent through a fund which is available to the government of India which is collected from Indians outside India. So for every service that an Indian embassy does, it charges a small amount that money is kept and is used by the external affairs minister at his discretion given when there's a crisis. So money is available.

So you use that money to get them to a nearby place cross the border and there the other embassy takes over saying that okay now you are in say Armenia the Indian embassy in Armenia will arrange for you to move from there to the airport. Perhaps again they will provide the buses and from there they will fly them back to Delhi and all of this is for free for Indian citizens or do we have to pay for it? No, as of now the Indian government of India uh has been very thoughtful in doing that. Yes, some people misuse it because even if you give an advisory they will still go but the instances are smaller. But do we have to pay or no? No, you do not have to pay. These are all funded through the uh there's a welfare fund which is drawn uh by the government through services and kept aside for such contingencies. But as a diplomat do you need to take permission that I'm doing this I'm arranging a bus and a flight for my citizens to go here and whose permission do you need? So uh in a war uh in a war situation you will always ask the local government because they should not think that they are doing something which is against their laws. So that's number one from the ministry of external affairs. Government government of India approves and generally they have been very liberal in approving. Everywhere you see Indians coming back uh flights being chartered, air force planes being given uh ships being uh used. So government of India spends and if there is any cost it will bear the cost. Okay. And how fast is usually this approval? How we see it in movies? It's like somebody from some other country keeps calling Indian embassy and then or the Indian ministry here and they takes like oh we'll get back to you I'll talk to the minister I'll talk to the prime minister I'll talk to like you know how movie exaggerates and takes like hours or probably days and weeks before they start so um two things one is um the money within the country there's enough surving in Saudi Arabia if anybody wants to get you want to move from one place to another there's enough already fund available And there are limits in the ambassad of India will bear the cost. So there are such situations but otherwise I think the stories that you're telling are from Kuwait in 1990. Yes. But the India of 2026 is very different from the India of this money has never been an issue with government of India spending for Indian nationals. Interesting. Okay. Another thing is you said your largely job is to go to another country, build connections, understanding and improve relationships there. And the first sentence you said diplomats are trained liars for the country's interest, right? Everybody knows that diplomats going to lie because of country's interest. Why would any other country trust you? You will not trust that person on everything. So by definition diplomats are if I may say um what you use in Hollywood and Bollywood as frenemies. Okay, friends in some areas, competitors in some areas and opponents in another area. So each will decide. Diplomats know how to work with each other. They each knows whether he is saying too much, he staying too less. Does this meet my interest or not? So no country even if I speak everything which is 100% truth is going to accept it at face value. They will only decide what is in their interest. I will only say what is in my interest. So ultimately it's a matter of interest. And whether you say truth, don't say truth, you say anything. If interests match, things will work out. If interests don't match, you can do what you want. It will not work. So there's rarely anything emotional about it. Everything is transaction. And if the interests match people would trust with even even then when you trust at that time also you will be little cautious that oh this might happen this might not happen but usually when the interests align you do it. Sure trust but verify is a norm that all diplomats follow. Are there who are the most trustworthy diplomats I don't know. Now you're asking a diplomat who's lied so many times to answer this question. Indian of course as an Indian who who have you found very trustworthy and it can be an individual this is not from India's point of view from your own experience so who which country's diplomat has been so as we have grown up with the belief that India's best friend

is Russia this is a belief and it's a perception whether right norm I don't know but generally we found them forthcoming and helpful in our cases because we have no major clash of interests with them. So from our younger days we were taught that in crisis look at uh countries who are helpful and Russia was certainly one of those countries. Can you trust France? Of course we can trust anybody if the interests match if the interests align I'm ready to trust everybody. Okay I have a slightly different question because I just brought France. I was talking to an ex CIA person. Okay. And they said he like he said that nobody trusts France in America. Why? I don't know. There's a there's a history behind that. Although during the US fight for independence, France was their amongst their best friend. M but over the years some people think that many Europeans including perhaps the French are those who are much more commercially oriented but they're promoting their interest as a country's interests change the view of the world will also change for them and for the others and it's normal and that's what we see in our country also young Indians are not interested in doctrine now they are interested in whether foreign policy brings me jobs, whether foreign policy opens up opportunities for me, whether foreign policy will get me visas easily. True. So, it's a more transactional approach and it's a some people may say it's a narrower approach, but I think it's a more demanding approach that young people want foreign policy to explain what you're doing for me like you've been asking what are you doing, what's in it for me, not the doctrine. The doctrine is important. The principles are important but everybody doesn't see it purely from a doctrinal and a geopolitical lens. We see it from economic interest lens and I don't see why it's unfair for people to see it that way because what serves your interest you will do that like because because now France is a good friend of ours. So probably because the interests are lining and as everybody says there are no permanent friends no permanent enemies they just and you know what's interesting today's geopolitics or like the world and even perhaps the job of a diplomat we are living in a world which is where everybody has understood that this is geopolitical confr like no more is enemies or collaboration or cooperation it's I think you have also said somewhere that we are in a competition. Yes. So now there's world is in a competition not in a cooperation mode. So it's interesting. Now before we take over world I want to talk about cooperation, collaboration, competition with our you know bad neighborhood where you have also served for a while in Pakistan. How is it different to serve in Pakistan versus the world? So or like what rather what it is like to be a diplomat in Pakistan right so I served in Pakistan during very tumultous times um we had Cargill there we also had Prime Minister Vajay's Lahore Yatra so I could see on one side when there was a lot of Bonhomi and within a short period what uh difference happened so from the perspective of working in Pakistan. It's very different for an Indian diplomat to work in Pakistan from anywhere else. Actually, I worked in Pakistan after I first served in the UN. So, we have a a system in the foreign service of equalizing. You do a very comfortable place, you go into a difficult place. And so, I was paying for my sins of being in New York once going to Pakistan. But uh to me it was one of the most challenging uh places to work in uh for an Indian diplomat. So the challenge is not only for the diplomat but for their families. So my wife would say that if she goes to a shop there is somebody from their intelligence following her and then the shopkeeper says otherwise that guy is following everywhere. So you can see the what you would call the mental stress that the families are when you are outside India your island of support is your family and your embassy because there are small number of people. Now if they start getting stress or the children start getting stressed you're naturally going to be more stressed than otherwise. So there's number one is that but more difficult is do they face threat? Pardon? They don't face threat but they face continuously hostile um and intrusive monetary

but there must be some inherent threat right you can't trust that country of course like you can't trust anything that the prime minister says how can you trust somebody who's on a local level sure and that's true but we haven't had occasions except in some cases where you had physical threat but it's the mental harassment is enough to keep youhuh uh worried for all times. So there's one thing about the family but more important is that you see you are a targeted person anytime you are there for example your car I think the Indian number plate was 27 so wherever you go 27 they'll say Indian so it's and Islamabad is not like Delhi or Mumbai a huge city it's a smaller city and so everybody knows who is an Indian who's not an Indian some of the other diplomats are also a little kg of meeting you because their primary job is what their primary job is to work with the local people. So they don't want to engage very much with you. Uh given the they want to be seen as engaging with the locals and people have a fear. So you have a fear and the people of Pakistan are generally much more forthcoming than their government. But that said the people are kept away. They are not allowed to engage with us. So you become more insulated. uh you find it difficult to engage with them and then as you said diplomats the life of the country and Pakistan is the master in deceit and deception so we get used to them telling no don't worry we'll go do this this is no we didn't know this that etc but in reality we know where they are coming from but we have no expectations because that's the nature of their state their state thinks or it's built on an ideology that um if India succeeds they fail this is their simple ideology and therefore they will do everything to undermine us and our goal is to make our country successful. Pakistan frankly to me is something which is in our rear view mirror. It is going back further and further and we need to look ahead and it will remain a problem because of the asymmetrical threat they pose to our society because they think their society cannot flourish if they see a flourishing India and that's the big thing they have to overcome. We I think need to look forward and Pakistan will remain a major concern for us in a security. Yeah. But economically in terms of well-being we have moved ahead and I think our way is to look forward rather than to keep looking at the rear view mirror because they will keep falling back. We've looked at it cricket when I first was watching cricket Pakistan used to beat us all the time. Today every time we say number eight we have beaten them zero whatever else etc and all. So it's a reflection of the reality of the two countries. We moved ahead and we are now realizing our potential. They are falling back. Got it. But why do we even need to be there as a diplomat? What's the need to be in Pakistan? Because and I'm saying this, you can't trust the country. You don't find any favorable uh conversation or behavior when you move there. Anything that you will try to do, they'll try to do probably opposite. You don't have friends. Whatever you if you'll come down to some sort of uh mediation, some kind of solution with their local authorities will be overturned by either army or somebody which has vested interest and you face perpetual threat when you're there. Right? There's no scope for dialogue as well. every time you have tried to do something they still come back and do something with security. So why do we even need to go there now when we have we've seen enough times that nothing happens and nothing has been achieved even after we go there. You're right in a way. But let's look at at it in a different manner. So it's a country of 200 million. It has no beneficial impact on us like you've listed. But its scope for creating unnecessary problem for us is immense. So if we have a limited we don't have a huge establishment. If we have a limited presence of those who understand that society who can read that society because it's important to understand what your enemy is doing because we can then be prepared. So that small presence serves a purpose. Uh every presence doesn't need to be expanded. Those days are gone. We have a limited presence. We don't have as you said for all the reasons there's no dialogue going. But understanding that society and the

way it is evolving is important because we can't change geography. Geography is what binds us together. Prime Minister Atal Bihari used to say that this is it for good or bad we are linked together and we need to understand what are the not so good trends in there so that we can take evasive action not that we get it right we may get it wrong also but it's worth that small little investment where we are back to when I started I told you observation was the only thing that I was gaining in some places I'm back to in Pakistan the relationship is that primordial that only observation finding out reporting here sometimes we get it right sometimes we may not get it as as a diplomat there in Pakistan were you able to gather realtime observation or information which would be true because I would assume that half of their resources on you would be how you should get wrong information and deceitful information so that you don't get it right ever so everything which which would come to do would be tampered in some way. Sure. But I'm not talking of uh closed information. Okay. There is open- source information which is available. If you can understand UDU, you can read their papers. So you can understand that there are trends growing. Mhm. Interesting. I mean, how does how did the ceasefire happen? Like what's the process of it? So is it like America pressured us and they mediated what's the problem like how did it happen? So let's be clear in India Pakistan ties there are only two parties there is no scope for it's a doctrinal principle for us that there is no scope for now it has been said that there were many countries who were saying look you all are our friends please don't engage so Saudi Arabia was engaged UAE was engaged Qatar was engaged because they see a large amount of Indians Pakistanis in their society also and the US was also engaged so that in these sort of thing there are lots of messages passed on that okay they are saying and they say okay you tell us. So our understanding has always been yes we have been communicating with everybody saying the same thing that if Pakistan stops we are ready to have a ceasefire and yes maybe that message was communicated through various ways and Pakistanis as you said they wanted to verify and trust so they contacted us and we then said so the final decision and the initial impetus was ours whether it was through different channels and many people were involved in that perhaps but that doesn't make them mediators that doesn't make them facilitators it makes them communi in this day and age people can communicate through different ways may have communicated I don't know so it's so the Pakistani chief or army person called us to confirm that I've heard this is this what is okay with you and we said yes if you say we are ready and let's agree to this. Okay. So, it was final agreement is between us. It was also that uh uh that it was only them and us. Nobody else. Yes. Everybody will say don't fight. We need to have peace. We need to you both of you should work out. And that's not unusual for any country to say. We also say in other conflicts. So why is like Porus asking for credit? So you know uh all my understanding of global issues is linked to understanding international relations. But to understand Porus you need a psychoanalyst. I mean you need to understand what goes in his mind. Yeah that I'm not competent. I must say I haven't learned those arts. I have learned arts which are more conventional. But it was not him who did that. Okay. There was a badass move that you pulled while ago which was in regards to Pakistan when Pakistani ambassador came answered nobody. Chinese ambassador came answered nobody like I mean took no question from the press. You went there and you said I will actually take questions. You took five questions, right? And made sure that you release a statement that I'm doing five times better or like I'm allowing five fivex more questions to be asked to me as India and you allowed everybody to ask you questions. Few of them were Pakistani journalists. You went to Pakistani journalist, you shook hands and you told them that uh stop war, stop terror, stop terror and then start dialogue, right? Because they were saying that why not when will you

start talking about India and Pakistan and when the dialogue will start? That was one of the most badass moves. I'm sure thousands of people have told you. But do you genuinely believe that stopping every dialogue with Pakistan just ignoring them blatantly is the way forward until they stop terror? So um uh states communicate with each other in many ways. M uh we cannot have an official channel to uh smooth our ties unless they stop terror because it's just not acceptable in a democracy. uh we've tried this many times. Uh previous governments used to say there should be uninterrupted dialogue and we realize that it's not working. So the best way for India Pakistan is to ensure a back channel and a back channel has its advantages. It can be denied. It can be questioned. It can be it doesn't exist in reality in uh in in media light. So perhaps that's the best way but no formal talks until back channels work. I mentioned to you in the sack first time back channel seems to have worked. Prime Minister Nawas Sharif came despite the foreign office saying that he's not going to come. So there are back channels of people who can work this out and this is the common practice in difficult situations. So you can have back channels. uh they say that the ceasefire and part of it was also through back channels but uh back channels will inevitably mean some Indian person and some Pakistani person and this happened even during Lahore I was I remember even during Cargill there were back channels of different people helping out passing information uh telling Navas Sharif that your army is involved so back channels are an important thing and maybe that's the best way front channel serves no purpose we've tried it it will not work because both have to come back and explain and it's not until you have some commonality there's nothing there to explain but it's it's been more than 24 25 years now that we're facing terror from them and the terror has not stopped yet so our long-term strategy of whether back channeling channeling it or being at the front front foot everything has failed at what point does any of our strategy work because they're just being reckless day by day. So a a state which is being reckless, we can ignore if if it is far off, if we have a border with them, whether we like it or not, the effort of some sort should be there present every time. Otherwise, we are in a world where it's very easy to create narratives. M uh and it's best that even if it is for narrative sake we better have it because we not only have to win the battle against terrorism but we have to win the battle of narrative against terrorism and that's as important and so for those you can knowing fully well that it may not work try it prime minister Modi went to Lahour not because he thought everything will change he thought give it a try we know it didn't succeed and we followed that path. But it is important for back channels to be there because we are both nuclear countries and we don't want to go down that route and it's important to have a modicum a minimum level states should have minimum level of contacts whether recognized or not it's not the issue. We'll come back to them again when I talk about other countries relation because other countries also crucial in this particular part with them. Let's talk about your other win. One of the big wins were ICJ, right? Uh you what was that scenario? Explain us that you helped India become the judge of the ICJ and it was for the first time that from a permanent five members somebody who has a non-permanent member who beat a permanent member right explain us that entire in detail so that we know. So you see um uh elections in a country attract attention. Everybody says now we're going to have elections everybody is following. What is that election to international bodies don't attract that attention. So people think that we try and we win we win we don't win we don't win. So it was one of those elections where we had decided that maybe we will not contest. This was to the international court of justice. uh we had thought that okay it's a far off body it may not have an impact on India why do it and then something happened which may just change this was the issue of Kulbushy because we took it to the ICJ because we found a small little opening that we can

use internationally to stop his execution and because military code there in Pakistan had given the uh decision to execute. So we went to the international court of justice saying that Pakistan is vi in violation not of a bilateral treaty but their commitment to the world and that is a convention which Pakistan benefits also from and they couldn't say no. So it went to the ICJ and we won that case. Then we realize hey it's important for us to have some guy there not because he will totally change the view in front uh for us but we can understand what are the thinking in those places if we have a permanent person there again uh just a small little one person and we thought this is important so we decided to contest but we were too late and again I was one of those who said we are not going to win because most people contest and canvas for that for more than a year a year and a half some and we had from June to November about 5 6 months and I said we don't win and then it was decided the prime minister said I know that you don't think it is that decision is taken now if the prime minister of India says this decision is taken I'm there to implement it so he said what you want I will do But this decision is taken. You have to contest. I know your views. And but that discussion is over. And so I went back thinking that what am I stuck in this? How am I going to win this? My career is gone because you know I cannot say no. But I had said no. All these things are going through my mind. Then we decided that look uh every time there is a regional division. When we read it, we found that there was no formal regional division. M so you could there were five places there are seven judges only five will get selected doesn't have to be region although the conventional till then was that every region should get one and we knew the one from our region they had been canvasing for a long time and it was difficult to just get into a one-on-one so we expanded our interest beyond Asia we started uh seeking African help we started seeking Latin American help and India's network was very So I was only the if I may say the trench warrior there. There's a whole big system behind it. The external affairs minister, the prime minister and one of those stories I can tell you. The first vote that we got was before we announced formally and I think prime minister met the um president somewhere. So the ambassador came to me I need to meet you urgently. And I said yeah where should it come? He said I have a request that I'm going to vote for you. I said but I haven't announced the candidate. He said no here's my letter. No candidate vote for India's candidate. So it enthused us so much because here was a guy coming and telling before we announced based on the talk between our prime minister and their president and that told us that no we have to push because it's serious business everybody is involved and so for the first time we won. You see the UN has a if I may say a um a flaw in that it ensures that only five countries who are permanent members will scratch each other's back and the others we are like lesser humans and we realize that that if you are fighting against the UK in a 15 member vote They already have five tied up because they are all friends. Those five will vote for each other. So the others they need to get only three more or four more out of 10. We have to get eight out of the 10. And that was a difficult thing but we just pulled it off because I think many who were telling the UK no we'll vote for you were also willing and you know diplomats they are ways on ways of communicating. So we won that election purely because of the push of the bigger machinery we had um smaller countries because everybody's vote counter US also supported right Nikki Haley yes so Nikki Haley to be fair uh shut down the US opposition to us so the understanding between her and me was that we are both friends don't choose between friends we understand you have to vote for them and that's all right you vote for them but don't canvas against us and to her credit she immediately shut down saying that I agree with you I will not I have told my people don't canvas against India but you know we have this long tie up and that was fine the US they voted some someone else yes they voted for UK but they did not canvas because they

were canvasing against us canvas meaning they were not putting their candidate in front of us no they were going to other countries and saying hey why do you want India because you know UK is a better friend. I mean we have seen this their relationship is um decades and perhaps centuries old. So they were saying and we said fine let's agree to a via media you support them we will not ask you for your vote but you don't go and ask others not to vote for us and that helped uh in a way and a lot of countries helped us small big etc. It also was a reflection of India's coming of age uh at a diplomatic level. So you called over 60 people. What was it? Yes. I mean called, pushed, texted, did a lot of things. You know, in diplomacy you have to use a lot of tools and it's best I don't reveal those tools because some are not savory, but it happens. What's the most not savory tool you have used ever? I I'll I'll make sure that I don't relate it to this one. I'll take it as a hypothetical some other situation. Well, you know, tell me a tool. No, there are multiple tools for countries like India. So, we also are providers of assistance. We uh we say okay, I will vote for you in this, you vote for me in that. Uh and so there were many of these you scratch my back, I scratch your back. Uh it's normal in diplomacy give and take. Normal diplomacy is always give and take. There's no such thing. I take everything and US can do that. They do. Pardon? Well then they land up in problems. No country through diplomacy. Then there is another form. You call it war, you call it force etc. In diplomacy you only win by taking more. You don't win by winner takes all. You you take more, somebody takes less. And that's give and take. And that's part of diplomacy. Anything more it has to be force or war or battles or there are some other tools that are available. Got it. But on once we became once we got this position right judge at the ICJ which is a prestigious position do you think we we didn't use it to a fullest? So the issue is that the judge is an independent judge and to be fair our judge was a judge of the Supreme Court who has a a record of uh independence. So our issue is not that uh we didn't want an independent judge. He is independent and that is how it should be. But what happens is in these matters if you start engaging at that thing otherwise it's a blank hole. We don't know what it is. we then realize that okay in this case I can do a trade-off somewhere somewhere something else etc and all so it's important for a growing power to have representation in every place it's important for that like we have it's not the uh cost benefit for relationship with Pakistan is very small we don't gain much but we don't lose much also so even with the ICJ it's an important international law thing yes some countries don't obey the law that's all Right. But as a rising power, as a power which wants to expand its influence, it's best for India to be on all high tables. Got it. But some I was reading a critique and the comment was that India even when they got the judge position at ICJ showed that they only care about their interest in Kulvotion case and like they were only bothered about their own issues. they lost an opportunity to grow their influence and show the world that the world matters also can be dealt with Indian power or Indian diplomacy or India's opportunity at a high seat table. Did you use that opportunity? No, I think it's a unfair criticism for the simple reason the judge is an independent judge and he has given several independent judgments. It doesn't reflect the Indian government's view. the government of India. Even within India, the judges have he care about Indian issues. No, he is participant in all. So he participates and votes in every judgment that comes in front of the ICJ and to his credit. Uh I think whoever wrote this may have written in the first flush at that stage. Today he has given judgments and his individual judgments in a whole host of cases and it shows that an Indian judge can also stand up and in some cases at the cost to India also because you see again countries look at this differently than judges do and some countries may be happy with us some countries may not be happy with us but that's part of the power game as you grow you need to be in every place you may gain some some you may not

gain from some. Yeah, you also personally led the 10-year campaign in front of UN to make sure that Masud Azar becomes a global terrorist and get tagged at that. Right. After 2611, it took you so many years to do that and convince. Every time you would put that in front of the global board, China would block it. True. Right. And eventually I think in 2019 it happened that they called and they tagged Masud Azar as a global terrorist. Yes. What do you think? What convinced China to not block it anymore? So you're right that this was a U effort that we were putting for several years. Many of my predecessors tried. I myself tried. This was not my first attempt. I tried. So what happened was that this was after uh the uh terrorist attack in 2019 uh in Jammu and Kashmir. Um and so uh what happened was it was so egregious that the whole world felt that you know this was not something uh that is acceptable. Now we knew that China would again create problems. So the only thing that made me do is I said I lost three times before. I've tried it didn't work out. Let me try another time. And this time you see we did a procedural thing which is different from the past. What we did was we said all right if you block it we will take it to an open meeting and you or whoever is against it will have to justify openly why you're doing it. Before it used to be in a committee and this was not something that they bargained for because the Chinese like to do these things quietly under the table. He didn't veto. Yes. They didn't want to do it openly and so they started negotiating with us saying we were in an election thing. So they started saying that oh this is election related and I told them but you didn't allow us in the beginning before our elections were declared. now because elections are declared you are using our domestic issues with them and we said all right we worked with all the 14 other countries saying that let's put it to a vote and I was thinking that okay let China veto it openly saying I veto this uh designation of this terrorist and that was fine even if we lose it. So I think they also calculated that the price was too much for them and so it was how much you raise the price in a negotiation. Everybody has a price and at a certain stage you give up because you think the price is too much and I think in that one we were fortunate that we raised it in such a manner that the Chinese were not able and then they just haggled about the date. They told us 15th April, 22nd April, finally on 30th or 1st of May or something. They agreed. Uh it was during the election period etc. But it was of course a come down for them but they realized it is a smaller loss than going out and defending them publicly. Yeah. So because you were louder and you were more public about their hidden agenda and how they are blocking blocking a tag of somebody who's a who blatantly big criminal and and a terrorist all around the world they they saw it as a loss. Okay. So because it was because of loud. So one side of me in this wants to appreciate you because somebody who caused so much trouble in our country is finally now tagged as a global terrorist is not being allowed to travel freely. There's a travel ban, there's account freezing happens, funds will not be able to rotate very freely to him. The bunch of things which will happen. So a part of me who's Indian want to really appreciate like thanks for doing this. But other part of me also says what different does it make to him because he's a global terrorist still surviving still doing the mischievous things still causing troubles to India getting all his weapons from back channels from all around the world probably China supplying some of their weapons also openly in public forum he's going out and talking about taking revenge for his family members account freezing I think makes no sense Because terrorists would never do it publicly on their accounts. Travel ban makes no sense because they will not travel openly. They'll travel in shadows. So what different does it make to call him a global terrorist and do all of this nuisance? So you're right if you see it in very if I may say hard power terms but you also have to see it in a different light which is not everything or nothing. In life there are many shades of gray. So there is do everything kill him put him under arrest etc or do nothing this

is somewhere in between and in international law that's what is maximum feasible but more importantly is that even today Pakistan says he's not in Pakistan so you can see that even they will they keep on saying that he's not there the foreign minister has repeatedly said we don't know where he is what he is doing uh periodically they say maybe he's dead also. So at least the narrative part we are gaining. So this is a complex situation of one eliminating terrorism fully which I agree with you that it hasn't led to but it has given us the upper hand in narrative building. It has made even Pakistan weary of saying that no actually he is my asset etc. openly in subterraneanly what they do is a different uh situation. So I would think we've gained a little uh it's minimal gain but it's nevertheless a gain in diplomacy small gains add to a big kill and so if it wasn't there's other guy Hafi sah he's also been done and yet every few years he tries and says lift my ban I'm no longer associated so if there wasn't an impact they won't be doing it obviously there is some impact not to the extent than we want but there's some impact that's why they are saying remove this ban on me I'm now an honest citizen I'm not associated with this this grouping at all that grouping doesn't exist also they say they change the name that's fine but I think we must not disparage the incremental gains you said in diplomacy there's gray lines every time I hear gray from a diplomat my my antenna goes up And it reminds me of greylist FATF's grrey list. Pakistan has been on FATF's grrey list at least three times. Yet no country which is our friend has formally designated Pakistan a sponsor of terrorism. Right? We've been trying it for so many years. Nobody calls them out for thing. What what are we doing wrong? Why hasn't India been able to actually prove Pakistan as a state of terror? So in international law, there is no such thing as a terror state. It doesn't exist. The only place it exists is the US. US designates state otherwise in so for example the reason is terrorism is seen as a individual crime. Legally terrorism cannot be within a a state's role because a state within its territory has sovereign authority. So it cannot be a promoter of of terrorism legally because in legal terms a sovereign even if he's a despot cannot be a terrorist. Terrorist is an individual or a group. So the whole international architecture of counterterrorism is designed only for groups or individuals. Isn't it lopsided and flawed? Again I think we are back to that same argument is everything or nothing. Okay let's say so let's say US decides. Okay, for example, forget us, we are in G20, we are in quad, we are in a we are in bricks, we have so many our friends all around the world. They also help Pakistan. Our friends can start at least probably putting sanctions or some kind of economic damage to them. But this doesn't seem to happen. What's the point of India being friends with so many people and being in so many these institutions when we can't even tackle forget tackle our problem of neighborhood we can't even make our friends convinced that they are a sponsor of terrorism don't support them so much so yes one is you're looking at the formal designation I am looking at who's investing in Pakistan now now US is right isn't it now US I'm saying in general but none of the Europeans are investing in Pakistan because they see their investment not getting returns. So you have China investing and even China has pulled back its investment compared to what it said. It said 60 billion under the belt and road today it is much lesser than this and they realize that they have a problem. So I think what we need to look at is again that we are building blocks. It's not it's a work in progress. Don't see it again as an end by itself. a work in progress in international law. You see, you are young so you are used to a system where if you take your mobile phone, you press it updates. And so within 5 minutes everything is changed. Yeah. I live in the harsh realities of countries where change is only incremental. So I gain a little bit. I'm happy with it and I start building more. What have we gained over the years at least with in regards of this problem terrorism like over the how and okay let's say we've called them we've identified few terrorists and we have made them global terrorists we have told the

world that they are doing this but in the narrative war they're still getting support of two superpowers that is China and US probably that that's the only only country in the world which is getting support from both of these superpowers who are also anti in some sort. So what are we able to do? Their investments weapon investments or infrastructure investments is being sponsored by China. So they are helping IMF international investments which is largely US they're also helping them. So how have we able to block them from anything? So here's the challenge. You are looking for for India, Pakistan is a smaller country. Uh it's a much smaller country. It's a nuisance country. True. But for the rest of the world, they're looking at that it's a 200 million country and they're looking at it could become worse. So the for example the IMF etc and all they look at it things will be worse than what they are today. M uh we are of the view that nothing is worse than now. We've already seen them. I mean it's only a shade better or shade worse and that's all. But for the others you know there was a time when every terrorist even now look at the list of terrorist acts anywhere you will find some linkage with Pakistan. So the rest of the world is worried that it may have more and more of these. uh we have been by and large been able to insulate them from us. Yes. Now we also have a much more proactive uh response that should there be a terror attack we will respond. So we are not looking at the world for all that. We are looking at the world only as a stage where we can promote our view not as somebody who will help us. We will handle Pakistan ourselves. Uh frankly um young India an assertive India can handle Pakistan by itself. It is a challenge but it's not what it was once upon a time where we were not even thinking of responding. Things have changed with us. We now have the capabilities to do this. So we will handle our terror problem ourself. And I think the bigger takeaway from a world of today is that countries are on their own. M absolutely absolutely see Pakistan you said like it's it's no more a challenge anymore so that's probably one thing for India it doesn't even concern India apart from few security reasons young India is not bothered about them I think young Pakistan also is not bothered about Pakistan itself they also I I meet so many uh you know when you go to UK or US and you bump into some Pakistanis and they are fed up of their institutions themselves. If they probably have some sort of right or influence, they'll be the first ones to finish off all their problems way before India as well. Right? So that's gone, that's done, but there's still a problem. And to me that's something concerning that why India as a growing power not being able to finish all their at least terror support if not let's say humanitarian grounds you support them to build infrastructure 200 million people's life are in danger etc etc etc just cut off their like their terror funding in some way can't we do No, I mean you see you can do that if it is not state sponsored. No, if it's not state sponsored. If a state uses terror as a means of is as a weapon, you can't do that because can't the world see that. The world is embroiled in its own problems. We agreed that let's keep let's keep the world out because the world we've tried this. We went to the UN on Jammu and Kashmir and we know what happens because the world looks at these things from their interests. They do not look at right or wrong. Everything is interest based in a uh engagement of states. So some states may gain, some states may not gain, some states may have an issue with India and all. So this is not the game we should play of looking at the world to solve our problem. We are big enough. we will solve it in incremental ways and that's the best way to do it because it should not disrupt our own development our own growth as you said Pakistan itself the challenge is their own domestic challenges are much more than external challenges for them and they will sort themsel out or they will be pulled down by themselves let's focus young India should be aspirational should look at thing yes we should ensure that our security is not undermined that's the only issue as far as Pakistan is concern concern for us that they don't undermine

our security and we have been becoming more and more assertive in that. Let's hope that the last assertion uh sends a signal that terrorism may lead to much sharper responses than it has in the past. Okay. You also said like US tags it right and I think as of as we speak right now director of intelligence Tuli Gabbard if I'm pronouncing her name right. Yes. She said Pakistan is a nuclear threat. All of a sudden Pakistan is a nuclear threat now. So do you think that A has to do something with India's influence over the world and B is it that maybe after this statement world will look at Pakistan a different way or nothing will happen? No, it's not always between nothing or everything. Okay. We what's what's in between? What's your guess that what will happen if US calls somebody a nuclear threat? Do they do something about it or do they just make a statement and keep it? So no, they do do something but it's always a balance. They will always look at okay is this worse for us or is this better for us? Right now they have quoted in the nuclear field they feel that is a threat. However, they may see it's help us in something else. I don't know what is the deal between Pakistan and the Trump administration and a whole host of other things. They will do their calculations. Again, we don't need to look at the world for our solutions. Our solutions will be homegrown. We will have to address it ourselves. And that's how a power will do. The rest of the world is only limited role. And either foreign policy or diplomacy can play a limited role. And let's not make it the only player in this act. I mean for us we are the only players right because everything concerns us. So our worldview you might say it that okay there is very little that we can do but I think in today's world there's a lot that can happen if we don't do even the little or a lot right so there's there's a lot of problems going on. Let's look at India's worldview and India's current stance. Right? First is we are friends with Iran and we're friends with Israel. We are friends with America and we are friends with Russia. We deal with France and we deal openly or through softly in certain way through China as well. Right? So countries that hate each other all around the world, we are friends with all of them. Is this a right strategy? So as a country's interests expand, it has to engage with everybody. Now whether you call it friendship or not, let's leave it. But engagement with everybody is essential because your interests are so diverse. Let's take Iran, the Gulf and America or Israel. These are four people coming from different directions. So look at the Gulf. Look at our interests in the Gulf. The prime minister himself has gone 15 times to the Gulf countries. No other I think it's not acknowledged enough that that is the region which has changed its approach to India the most in the last 10 15 years. Uh 200 billion of our trade is with them. About 10 million Indians are there. So we have a large stake there. Right now you say all right so therefore we must always be only supportive of the Gulf which is the call that you would make if you look at this but let me see let me tell you what is in it for India to be uh engaged with uh Iran. Now Iran is a country of 90 million. It also is a country which provides us access hopefully either through Chabahar or through the north south transport corridor. Mhm. So our geography to the west is blocked by um Pakistan and Iran is the gateway for us to central Asia and the rest of West Asia etc. that side. So if we give up on Iran sure if I listen and say all right let's give up then you are reducing your strategic space. You're saying okay I'm going to give up on Central Asia totally they don't matter to me. But that's not what a rising power can do. It has to look at it that look at some stage I will gain from that. And finally Iran and India have a civilizational engagement which goes back hundreds of years also there are many Indians which who have cultural bonds with Iran like many Indians have cultural bonds with Tamils in Sri Lanka. So similarly Shiite Muslims in India have a cultural bond with them and we need to take that into account also. So for all those reasons we are engaged with uh Iran but we are not entangled with them. So we have greater stake in the Gulf. So therefore you have seen that we have been more viferous when the Gulf was

attacked than when Iran was attacked. But we are engaged with both of them without getting entangled. Now Israel. So Israel again our engagement with Israel has only grown. I have seen that as a diplomat in my lifetime that how much it has grown because there are defense engagements there are uh engagements related to um uh agriculture engagement to technology etc etc and there's a good increase now but prime minister has only gone to Israel only two times in the Gulf he has gone 15 times so you can see that we are moderating now some people say oh he went there and then Israel attacked Iran. Yes. Leaders go to everybody's countries. So am I responsible for what my host does then after 3 days? I am not responsible. You are just conflating my engagement with them bilaterally with their approach to the uh region. But will you not call it an intelligence failure? Why is it an intelligence failure? that 2 days before the big wars are going to happen, the prime minister of your country is there. So let's see how these things work. Security threat. No, let's see how these things work. These things are planned much in advance. Say 2 months, 3 months, maybe more. At that stage, there is no um indication of what is going to happen. How did that war the strikes happen? Israelis themselves have confirmed now it was because there was a target of opportunity that means somebody told them just just one day before or whatever that they are meeting so they went and struck now they could have if that opportunity was not there they would have done it later on maybe so why am I to be blamed if the intelligence at that stage didn't show me anything there's no intelligence which said that it will begin with that strike So I think it's unfair to conflate a leaders if we do this no leader will go to anybody else because after 5 days after 15 days there's something or the other happening in the world and you'll blame that leader saying oh you knew it it was an intelligence failure you didn't go there so I think it's unfair to uh place blame on a bilateral visit it was not a regional visit it had nothing to do with Iran etc and all it was a bilateral visit about improving our ties and those visits happen and they will continue to happen and we shouldn't read into it a larger motive or on the other hand blame it for a failure but why didn't we condemn when the attacks happened right isn't it like now that you said that Iran's important for us because they help us reach west Asia central Asia Israel is important to us because of defense and technology and precision tech which they provide us both are important. America is important to us because they're important to everybody. Surely because of the market capitalization that they have in the world, right? So everybody's a friend or let's say everybody is some someone who we want to engage with. Why didn't we condemn? Because my interests are higher in some other place. Am I going to condemn them when I know that there is going to be a attack from Iran on the Gulf where I have 10 million Indians there where much of my remittances come from where much of my oil comes from? Where much of my ura comes from? So I will calibrate. So calibration we are not in foreign policy is not a running commentary for cricket. I mean we have to calibrate and look. So we calibrated and saw that this is going to happen here and therefore let's not say we immediately uh spoke out when the attack was where our interests are in crisis we have to look out for our interests not for doctrines because the last uh the last strike and your condemnation of the last strike is not going to stop the next strike. We have to ensure that the next strike is not done and therefore we calibrated it's a judgment call it was done but we are not the only ones this issue was discussed in the UN recently 30 plus countries supported the attack uh condemn the attack against Gulf but they did not condemn the same attack against uh Iran so it's not that we are we are the only country which didn't do it we are in with the global mainstream which saw this as an interestbased issue and we look increasingly these are things that you weigh purely on your interests not only on abstract principles and you may say oh but we want to be principled in diplomacy we've been through

this engagement that principles are important but interests surmount principles but then when similar things happen in let's say Bolivia Pakistan an Oman their supreme leaders or their leaders or people at top leadership when they something happens to them we condemn even those are problematic states and it's probably against the interest of uh either Indian audienc's sentiment Indian citizens sentiments or world leadership or US at those times we have condemned always we have done it this time yes but our interests and we are limited compared to our interest in The Gulf, the Gulf is where our interests are. The Gulf is where we have invested more. So when we have invested more in Gulf, where our interests are more, why do we then send on a humanitarian ground, we send medical aid to Iran? Humanitarian assistance. Even the Gulf States will send look you cannot have all we have. Isn't it like we're we're displaying too much like there's no specific stance that we have? No, we have a stance like we are we are saying that hey on humanitarian grounds we're going to support you but we're not going to condemn your death. No look humanitarian grounds is a forwardlooking support. No it's like we're forward so we are providing medical aid to Iranian citizens. Yes. Right. In the Yes. in in the time of at the time of crisis. Yes. But we are not telling them that we are with you in like so like what's the what? So our signal is that we are helping you. We are talking to you because they are helping us pass our our tanks and our ships through their straightforward moves. So we are showing every signal in the world that we are in talks with them. Yes. But we're not telling the world that hey so you again you are only going to 100%. M you say be everything with Iran. I can be with Iran on many things. I need not be in Iran on everything. What you're telling me is either you be with Iran on everything or not on anything. And my view is I am with Iran on 60% of the thing, 70% of the things. I may not be in 100% of the thing. And this is acceptable in diplomacy. If it was not acceptable to Iran, why would they have left our ships? Fair. They they understand also that we have compulsions. They understand they have had compulsions. We have not told them that criticize everything that Pakistan does. We know that sometimes they are neighbors. They have challenges. So it's a issue of calibration and calibration should not be treated as weakness. Okay. So let's say India's strength right now is diplomacy talks all around the world and we are engaging with everybody. We have a lot of friends. We have less enemies. we have few in the middle. Okay. So that's where we are at and what is India doing right in this is protecting the interest of Indian citizens and because of which we have seen time and again whether it was Russia Ukraine war and sanctions against Russia whether it's tariff war whether it's Iran Israel Indian citizens are getting the help that that we want because of these talks. So right thing is we are getting the right price. Okay. And we have our trade on with everybody. We're not paying a premium in the world of war of somebody else's which is a good thing. What do you think? What's the price India is paying? So because everything comes with a price if we don't take a stance it's there's a price that we're paying. So we already praying a price for people who think that only doctrine should be the basis. not interest. So there will be some people who will feel like that who say doctrine is more important than interest. Now this is an age-old discussion. There will always be some in form of doctrine. There's someone in form of uh interest. So those who are supportive of doctrine will say but there is no country in the world which has only gone for doctrine. There's no country. So for example, Russia, Russia is critical of what they did, but they did in Ukraine. So it's not that they followed the doctrine always the same. So every country where its interests are concerned will let go of doctrine. Every country there is no country in the world which when faced with this crucial choice between doctrine and interest interests generally will generally will overcome doctrine and this is what is happening for us and there is no country in the world who hasn't done it including Iran I

know on discussions with on the um uh test ban treaty Iran was telling us oh you must fight you must not be against nuclear weapons etc you must against this bron testing. Finally, they went and voted for it because their interests were this is fine and every government in India does that. Do you think the price that we are also paying for protecting our interest by not taking side of anyone is that nobody supports us also when the crisis come? No. So why say when when this operation Synindur happened, none of our friend countries supported us. China, okay, not a friend, they didn't. Middle East, good friend, they didn't. Your Russia, good friend, they didn't. None. Like all around the world, nobody. America, in fact, Turkey, we had some relationship. They were the ones providing enough support and arms to Pakistan. America saying that we are friends with India. than actually influencing IMF to give money to Pakistan. So the price that India pays to stand in the middle is that nobody supports India as well. But you are assuming that India is wanting the support of everybody on that issue. This is what is India's position on India Pakistan issues says we keep the whole world out. M we will handle Pakistan ourselves. That has been the consistent position for 70 plus years that on these issues we don't want you. So all our engagement with the other countries was not that hey support us. Our engagement was to tell them okay this happened from now onwards if it happens get ready of what will happen. So if you have any no any leverage with Pakistan please tell them this is what is going to happen. We have told them but it's always good for the others to say. So it's preemptive in nature. Our engagement with the world after operation Sindur was a preemptive thing for the future not to gain support on that. We don't need support from I mean if you look at the countries we've gone. It was not for gaining support of some country or the other etc. It was to announce we have a new approach. This is the approach. Should Pakistan do it? Don't blame us in the future. And that's the way we need to look at it rather than we are not a country which looks at the past and tries to assuage the past. We generally have been forthcoming and saying that okay that has happened this if it happens in the future this is what we will do. We made our doctrine clear. Now if it ever happens again all countries know what we will do. You talk about doctrines and what we what we signal the world right right now I didn't get something I was very as an Indian for the first time I have to say that just like me there are thousands and millions of Indians who are also very happy that the way our leadership is handling the issues right now right that we are silent and we make sure that everything is smooth. And then the big proof point was Iran let our ship pass through. Okay, that was a big proof point. Then what became problematic to me, our foreign minister, he he he issued a statement that Iran is getting nothing in exchange. Right? That's what that's what he said. You you remember what he said about it, right? So if Iran is letting our ships pass, they are getting nothing in return. Now he also like there was also a statement that we are negotiating on phone or a tankerby tanker basis. Do you call it a success of a foreign policy that a foreign ministry is actually talking to Iran on a tankerbytanker basis? China has a framework, Japan has a framework, Russia has a framework. They all have a framework with Iran of how and what will happen when issues like this happen in the world. India is doing phone by phone. What how is this a success for us? No, it's a success because today of the ships being released. Russia has no ships there which have. So each country has a certain leverage. Okay. China's leverage with Iran isn't well known because 95% of the oil goes to China and it's so also it has leverage with them. So it has a different framework now. But does Europe have that framework? There are more than 120 ships stuck there. None have been gone. Only three or four have moved out of it. 22 ships are are also are also yes are stuck. Sure. because our leverage is limited to that and as leverage comes it will be worked out. So it's so the proof of the pudding is in the eating whether it was one by one or it

was all together is a processoriented issue. Uh on that you cannot decide oh foreign policy is successful because this is a process was more delayed. Some processes are more delayed, some processes may be easier and some countries have greater leverage, some countries have lesser leverage but we have maybe greater leverage with the Gulf. So you have to judge us with the level of leverage despite not despite being critical saying that oh India didn't conduct we were able to get our ships out at least two of them right now but 22 ships and 611 seafares all to the west of straight right so do we not have enough leverage to get that out as well so does France have so does Germany have so there are many other countries which are which uh the Japanese ships are stuck there. So it's not about doing it in the abstract. We have to look at it case by case and be a little bit more granular in our understanding. And in that granular understanding we are doing the best for our interest. We are gaining some others. So we are filling up from Fujira which is outside the zone. Indian Navy is bringing those ships to u uh to our ports and so we have increased purchases from somewhere else and that is because our ties with that country are perhaps stronger. We have greater leverage. There are there have been reports that a Russian ship which was going to China has diverted to India. So we have leverage there. So leverage can vary from situation to situation from country to country. You said let's go on a let's think about it on a granular level. On a granular level, do you think that the Iranian ships that we confesticated which were a part of shadow fleet, we had to let go of that in a part of negotiation right now. So first of all, what has been put out is that they are not Iranian ships. Okay? They are not owned by Iran. Okay? Uh but shadow fleet shadow fleet can be Russian can be any countries panian uh it can be Liberian etc. Shadow fleet is only those which are not insured through lawyers but are insured through other countries. Earlier it was proved that it was not actually proved but earlier it was accused it was accused but yesterday the foreign ministry has said first of all there is no such deal. Second is that these are not even Iranian ships. And third that we have not discussed this issue with Iran at all. So we'll have to go by what they said most recently. If they're not Iranian ships, why is Iran interested in them? So but Iran is right. We are leaving that ship, right? I don't know. We're releasing that ship. The two ships that we're releasing. No, no. Those uh which ships are we talking about? The Shadow Fleet. Yeah, the Shadow Fleet. I don't know. But maybe they're releasing but there may be some other trade-offs somewhere may not be this because trade-offs all countries have trade-offs all the time. I mean diplomacy is all give and take. So don't think that it's only take take that's only in chess we have take take and checkmate. You you recently put out an article about diplomacy and current situation of India, right? Where you addressed three challenges and three things that people are calling us out on, right? And you you gave a beautiful line there. You said we were poorer but louder. And what did you say? Can you complete it for me? Yeah. Wealthier and more guarded. What do you mean by that? So, uh I you know that's been a a thinking that I have picked up after my retirement. Okay. that when I see Indian foreign policy from outside that means I stay in Hyderabad for example it's not in Delhi so I see that the young and the ordinary Indian wants something else from foreign policy than the traditionalist wants and that is I want jobs I want um opportunities I want better visas I want remittances etc. etc. That's the young Indians aspiration. And I see that that's being reflected in our foreign policy because what has happened is in the 80s we were the most viferous. Uh we were more noisy. We were more upfront in giving a commentary on everything. So if somebody hits Libya, we would be the first to condemn. If someone goes to Venezuela, we would be the first to condemn. So we were openly speaking much more and then we were not because at that stage if you look at it and I have done a little bit of a study that in 1980s our economy was linked with the globe

about 15%. 15 17%. Today it's 50%. So the while India matters to the world the world matters to India also. Yeah. So we have to be more guarded and cautious and careful than we were in the past. And that's the reflection of India. You ask an ordinary Indian in the in Telangana or Hyderabad, they'll say are my cousin is in the Gulf. He sending their money from there. They want that sort of a security. So it's those interests have changed. Therefore, we are much more cautious in our articulation than when we were when we had nothing much to lose by saying anything to the world. We have been very critical of the US before. We have been very critical of other countries before because at that stage it didn't matter even for the world it didn't matter whether what India said. Today India matters and the world matters to India. H so you in that article you said because the growing influence of India we're rising silence is a strategy it's not a weakness and because the world matters to us way more than it used to so comparing what we used to do in ' 80s versus today would be not right way to look at it right but in that thing I want to read exactly a thing so that I don't miss out and correct me if I'm wrong you said that India's foreign polic policy should be judged not by ideological purity but by whether Delhi can reduce exposure without surrendering agency. That's exactly what you wrote. Yes. Right. Do you think that Okay. First is this is a good framing by a senior diplomat. Fair enough. Fair enough. It's a very I take it as a left-handed compliment. I'll pocket it. But I want to push you. Right. You you specifically spoke about whether Delhi can reduce exposure without surrendering agency and in this exposure you meant by three things energy, technology, capital. Our exposure on energy is on Russia. It has gone from 1% to 33%. Our exposure on technology which is on America and semiconductors is higher than ever. without them probably we'll be not here and our exposure in China we have subtly again started dealing with them and letting their capital come into our country right so the exposure in last decade has not reduced anywhere it has exponentially grown what exposure or reducing of exposure are we mentioning here so you're right that the exposure has not reduced that said the world has fundamentally changed in the last 10 years and we are in a transition and it's not proper to judge us in the middle of the transition and say if I tell you that in the middle of your exam I hold you and say hey this question you've done wrong so you will fail I have three other questions to answer give me my space to answer them so my whole point is yes our exposure has grown and we understand that and therefore we need to perhaps look at other forms of energy. So we've already started for example the nuclear the shanty bill or we are wanting to exponentially increase um the solar that will not uh mean that we need to keep on exporting importing more because this sort of a thing is creating vulnerabilities and those vulnerabilities when we have to face a situation like this constrain our approach. we then look at our interest rather than the doctrine. So we always if you reduce the vulnerabilities you have greater space to uh do your deals. So energy we have to reduce our uh our uh uh dependency because also we have to reduce the dependency from one region because now that one choke point has tied up maybe we need to do it and about Russia. So my view is simple on Russia that look it's a economic issue. We used to buy as you said be less than 1%. We increased it to 40%. Then we found that we are being uh charged more for our other thing. So we recalculate and say okay this I was gaining from that transaction. Now I'm losing from that transaction. So I recalibrate. So this has nothing to do with our ties with Russia or our friendship with Russia. It's a trade transaction and trade we need to be brutally clear that it's a give and take of econ economic. If the economic circumstances now are against us, I will not do. If it becomes better again, I will then do again. So we need to be frank enough to acknowledge that we don't need emotion in this. We need economy and calculation not emotion in judging our ties with any country. you were saying there were

vulnerabilities uh India you said we are India's interest and India is a growing power right and we should look at just our interest from completely economic standpoint not on any other standpoint and today if you criticize our strategy which you seem to like it at this point that silence is not weakness is a strategy which if people are commenting or questioning on it you feel that it's unfair because it's like middle of exam paper you asking me whether I failed or passed right that's what your stance is that's what you establish in the first half on this so in the same article you talk about reducing exposure in the same article you talk about being silenced right and right now you said that we need to think about our vulnerabilities don't you think This is the whole problem. As we grow more, we are getting more dependent. So the ideal way would be that we are a rising power. We need to be more independent and we need to manage our own things so that we can be more powerful in the world. And right now nobody questions me because I'm doing right. But as we grow right now, what it looks like at least judging it mid-exam paper because the facts are our dependency on energy, supply chain, global distribution, global influence, global power, neighborhoods around us, everything is increasing because our interests are rising, our interests are growing. And if the more and more the world deals with us, more and more we flourish. Doesn't that make us even weaker? Because if economics you're saying keep that in the interest like keep that as a forefront to decide all your policies and all your decisions. Right now our economic dependency or interdependency will keep growing. So that doesn't make us a powerful state at the end of the exam paper. that actually makes us the most black lab black male labelable society in the world because we'll be dependent on so many people as we grow more. So um you're looking at it in a linear manner that um I am here so I will just extrapolate from where I am to the next level. So it'll just grow. But um uh in the growth of economies uh it need not be just one straight line. M it goes and then there is an exponential change. And that's why all countries which are developing are usually debt ridden. Okay. It's normal that when you are growing you borrow more you put in investment and then the returns comes much later. So it's the same thing that what we are doing now getting from outside is to build from inside. For example, let's take again let's take solar or nuclear. Today we are dependent on China for solar modules. Okay. But once we have solar our dependence on electricity or energy from hydrocarbons will reduce. So you are not seeing the whole picture. You're saying that okay if I go like this I will have one say 100 megawatt or 500 gaw or 1,000 gaw it'll keep on dep increasing yes it'll keep on increasing but it'll end it's same with nuclear energy nuclear energy is very expensive in the beginning so you have to put up frontont all the cost after that your only cost is maintenance and uranium purchase so my point is that if you build the fundamentals or foundation ations here it will change towards the latter half and that's why I have answered the weakest question first and now come my stronger questions and you have just exponentially assessed me saying that okay first question two out of 10 so all questions two out of 10 I'm not going to be that next question is eight after that is nine after that it is 10 and then I'm through tell me the place where India is today where do we get two out of 10 and where do we get eight out of 10 as of now? Sure. So our dependence on energy is clearly a weakness. Uh and so the only way to counter it is to diversify so that we can have uh ability to trade off one against the other. M now that's one clear area energy because a fastgoing country needs energy and we will need much more now than we will need later on because then we will move to a phase where we don't need external energy will generate it internally. So right now our dependence is highest on energy. Okay. Next thing is capital. So we are growing at a time when capital movements are not what it was when China grew 25 years ago or 20 years ago. So investment has become more a challenge. A third one is exports. So China and most countries grew

because you could export to anybody. Today every country is saying no I will put barriers for exports. So our challenges have become much more than normal countries who have grown in the past their challenges were and that's why we are doing this more of tilling this way that way etc because the challenges are more we can't keep quiet and just do it we can't make too much noise and just do it. So you will see it as a contradiction. One way you're doing this, one way you're doing that. But that's how the world is and we have to navigate an uncertain world. We talk about all the challenges and I like talking about that a little bit more because it is economic point of view. But last question on the on the big challenge which is not economic which is about growing influence of India. So you said our influence is growing so are our challenges but over the years we have done a lot of good work yet after that we not been able to achieve anything in like anything with regards to let's say having our influence over international bodies for example IMF gave money to Pakistan for 24 times and that's I don't know how so even 25th time they'll be back and do it doing it right India says that Pakistan whatever they're doing is not our concern because we don't care right yet we protest it every time so we keep protesting it nobody listens to us what kind of rising influence is that so let me give you a counter to this Hyderabad h it's part of India. Yeah, agreed. Absolutely. There is no question about Hyderabad being part of India. Absolutely. Yeah. Perfect. Look at the record of the UN. Every year Pakistan there is an item on the United Nations Security Council agenda. The Hyderabad question. So let me explain what is this. You may be thinking strange I came back to Hyderabad. There is no question of a question of Hyderabad. there is an agenda item. So the way the process works in these international bodies is simple. If one country which has brought that dispute or that issue to the security council wants to keep it, it will be interally. If there is a case or not case or nothing there is no case about Hyderabad now but in 1947 when the nisam and the police action were be taking place this was an issue there at that time and it nothing happened there. it finished but Pakistan writes and it's continued now we have a choice we can spend our energy there or we can say nonsense let them do what they want how does it matter to me so this is whatever it will be there till Pakistan decides not to right and say so the procedure in these bodies is such that it is a if maze you can either bang your head and get hurt or find ways out of the maze. So I am not interested in finding a solution to this maze whether they want to write and is this a dispute. No, it's not been discussed for 75 years. It's not an issue for me. I don't see how it is. Even Pakistan doesn't see but it is out of cassidness. They write that every year they write please keep this on the agenda. So my point is that international bodies are reflective of the procedures they are. It's like UK. The UK is no longer among the top five countries in the world in any metrics. Yet it's a permanent member and we cannot change it because it's not like my instant phone. I cannot update it. So I either say I don't want anything to do with the UN or I say okay this part I don't take. I have many other things I'll do with that. So that's how we need to look at these things. I will gain what I want. The rest I'm not bothered about and it does not do any harm to me. It's okay. But are you comparing Pakistan's issue of Hyderabad with our issue with IMF? Our issue with IMF, we have always said this is not our issue. This we will protest and give up because in international law like don't we say in public in international law in front of the world that the world is funding if they're allowing IMF to actually fund Pakistan they're funding terrorism. We say open yet 82% vote come in favor. Yes. Because we are doing it to place our view not that we pushing. Look every negotiation we discussed there's a price to pay. You can pay the price and up it or you decide that okay I will not up it. I leave it at this price because it's not fundamental to my say. So are we ready to up the ante so much? We think that look today our share of the IMF is X which is very small. It's comparable to our

economy. Down the line when our economy grows when our share becomes up then we will still have this point to plug in. Then if I give it up now as a point and suddenly raise it afterwards unless I have a reason I will find it more difficult. So my thing is there are some enduring issues which we need to place on record but we don't fight hard hard adequately because there's a price you can get anything done whether here or elsewhere if you put in that much effort but you can't put all these effort for every time like we discussed on masudazar etc. We raise the bar so much but it's a one-time effort. I cannot keep on raising the bar every time like this. So I decide that okay I have if I may say so I have bigger fish to fry. So I'm going to look after those fish not this uh issue. It is difficult. It's not something that we like but I cannot solve all the problems of the world. Okay. So one side can be so let it be. The other side is where if tomorrow my contribution in IMF grows bigger I should be able to backtrack it that consistently over the years I've been able to block it. That's why now I'm raising the bar and like completely blocking it. Let's say in a hypothetical situation today we had to raise a bar and be like this is the issue we really care about and block their funding. What price potentially we could have been paid? No the price is that you'll have to give up your other goals. Obviously like what price what do you think what leverage other people will play on us? No. So the US will start saying will you follow us like Pakistan follows on everything? Are we ready? No. We are not follow US. No, we so I think it's so unfair to say we follow. Look at the board of peace. Trump has put up a board of peace. Pakistan has joined that. We have not joined it because we know this is not a real institution international institution. So we just say okay we haven't said we not going to join because you will unnecessarily antagonize it. You said we are considering it etc and all. We're not going to join it. So there you are. So look are you if you want to pay all the price then you won't be India. So India will do a balancing act. It's not a 100% clean act. It will be sometime this way that way etc. But that's the nature of the thing because our goals are different. We will sacrifice some smaller in negotiation or in anything. You give up smaller things for bigger things and that's our goal that we give up we look at the bigger things. Right now our goal is by 2047 we should be on par with developed economies and that's a good goal. It's a long-term goal. We all need to strive to that and see can we reach that smaller goals for the present we keep them on the back burner and see how it goes. See for that goal of developed economy rising economic interest everything right a lot of people say that we don't actually consider you US doesn't consider us a friend the critiques say that they are sort of our bosses whatever they'll say we have to follow do you believe in that no not at all but every time they say something we'll have to we eventually follow by hook or crook no I mean apart from the tariff We probably followed almost everything. No, I I think there are many many cases where we haven't followed. We don't openly say but is for example the US doesn't like us negotiating with Iran at all to get our ships. It hasn't stopped it hasn't stopped us from going and negotiating and we've openly said we doing it one by one. If it is working we will try again. The US doesn't want it wants people to send ships there mind sweepers etc and it doesn't even mention our name because they know that we are not a country which takes a side like that so there are I can give you another whole list of things where we are not so on the war in Ukraine did we support the UK US no the US as repeatedly vote for us don't abstain we didn't so I don't think there Anybody in the world who thinks that India will be following the US even the US doesn't think that way there may be some people who are here want to prove a point who say that but in reality it's not what the reality is a lot of people questioned it that and I was sitting with one uh very famous teacher in India he teaches geopolitics and trains I students and bunch of people for government exams right he's He's good informational guy and has a funny take as well. His

name is Khanser. I don't know if you ever know. Yes. Yes. Of course. Okay. You know him, right? So, but he said that uh us is our boss because a friend doesn't give commands. The friend can only suggest certain things. Like for example, Russia is a friend. Russia can say that yeah, don't do this. I can give you a better deal. And if I get give you a better deal, come deal with me. That's what Russia did in the US. uh Ukraine, Russia, scene, but US comes and be like stop this or else we'll do this. They threaten you, they command you. And right now the moment scene got little hard for them with the global economy with oil prices, they say we allow India. Who's US to allow India? How can US allow a nation which is independent, democratic and free? like why do we even hear these kind of statements and language without repenting? So what you're saying is that different countries have different styles of engaging with others. Um and what you're saying is that for example India different presidents and prime ministers and prime ministers have different styles. That's a fair point to make. But the US for a long time it acts and behaves like a great power. It is hierarchical in nature and so is China by that. China is also like this. the sort of things they were telling during galwan if you look at what they were saying we insist that India do this we do x so great powers who have a hubris will perhaps fall prey to hubris and it doesn't mean to say that what do you mean by hubris is overenthusiasm and sort of what we say arrogance all right arrogance and if you are a great power for a long time, you develop an arrogance. The Russians lost large amount of their territory. So they are not in the same league as the US because what is worse than losing territory for a country because it is a traumatic experience for any country if you lose a territory and therefore the Russians I mean look at us many people tell us you are too soft doesn't mean that if our demeanor is soft and we talk to everybody politely that we will agree to them. Oh, you're not too I I remember people telling me Maldives, how dare Maldives tell me anything. If I was there and this was another diplomacy saying if it was in my backyard I would have gone and hit them. Now that's their approach. Our approach is very different. We'll handle it in a different way. When they are in trouble they'll come to us etc etc. this happened Sri Lanka uh who was the first uh country to help them during cyclones during their big uh problem uh with yes with their economy we gave them3 billion or $4 billion but we haven't gone and told Sri Lanka do this do that I think it's a stylistic difference and style is important but we shouldn't mistake style for substance and it's better not to engage in style because different countries have different styles of telling. What is a style if you had to put it? Ours. Ours is a style of um being hard-headed but not showing it openly. So we appear soft but we are not all that soft. Yes, increasingly we are becoming assertive and that's the right thing because otherwise people may not take us seriously and but it's always a evolving thing. M we are transitioning from a country which was not so strong and powerful to a country which has a much stronger say now so we still have remnants of that past style and some people don't like if we are assertive also so we try to balance it no let's not do it right now we will do it in due course etc it's a transition which is a generational thing it'll take when young people like you are in positions of authority you may become more assertive and which is the right thing to do. Uh we have seen ourselves grow from a difficult situation and therefore we are much more cautious. Yeah. In our approach. Okay. So our style is that how would you call America's style? Explain in one sentence. In one sentence my way or the highway either you are with us. You think they're losing power on that? Yes. Clearly uh but they there were there was a time when America could get away by saying my way or highway today they're not able to do that. Absolutely correct because um uh you can say that when you were when the world was uniolar today they are not the only pole there. We can work with many others. Everybody else can work with others. And America uh has to come to grips

that this is not a uniolar world. But it's a more, if I may use a term, it's a world in which promiscuity is not a vice. It's not a human relationship but it's a state state relationship where you know you have multiple partners and you are proud that you have multiple partners. It doesn't work in an individual relationship but so that's how it is and the US has to get used that the uniolar moment it had a time from the end of the cold war till about 2007 etc. It could do what it want. It could get its act done today. No Russia style. Russia. So many people say Russia is always default position is nat. What do you mean by nat? Nat is no. So any view you say default position is no. Then begins the actual discussion. So many Russian foreign ministers were called Mr. Nat because the default position for anything is and I don't blame them because look at Russia in the past it was it has been the biggest loser in all these in terms of its uh strength or its global power weakening compared to what it was during World War II etc. that time it was part of the top three and then in a multipolar world when it parts broke off etc it had weakened so it doesn't want to change so it will be the most resistant to change and that's why they used to call it Mr. All right. Then Israel, I love like talking about styles of countries how they deal like based on your opinion. I am not too familiar but I have had some engagement with Israel and I find they are extremely strategic in their choices. Um many years ago, I had gone once to Israel with our foreign minister then and Natanya was then also the prime minister and he spent almost 3 hours the prime minister of Israel on a breakfast with the external affairs minister of India and it was clear to me that they had on a long-term basis said that this is the country that we want to engage in. So they would say whatever you want tell us not how to do it we will find ways you tell us what you want. So it's a style which is it they are thinking very long term we say that the Chinese think long term but the Israelis are thinking very very long term and that's part of their relationship with us is a thought process which started much earlier and they're a country which is about 12 million or something. They see a friendship and a long-term friendship with a country and they said perfect for us. I was speaking to someone senior in the international bodies and they said Israel you can define Israel's every move, every citizen's thinking, every government officer's thinking, every business person thinking, every person who has left Israel and is living somewhere else. You can define into one line. long-term strategy for growing influence because they want to survive. That's there's nothing else they do anything else apart from this. Whether it's their investment choices, it's their individual technology choices, innovation choices, building the family culture, dealing in wars or something like there's only one line. I think they've brainwashed themselves into just thinking this. Yeah, you may not be wrong because I came to almost the same conclusion without the existential threat and it's true those who have faced that sort of a danger will always uh think of it in existential terms and I understand where they're coming from but in that what has also happened is that sometimes there are excesses if you look at it in that manner but I because today's world they don't need to do this kind of stuff like today is not about existential crisis anymore. there was a time they need to be little. I agree with you absolutely because Israel is a country which has many advantages to it. Say and it's a country with a lot of thinking people. They are have contributed a lot to the world from the Jewish community. They have been great thinkers, writers etc and all. But I think they are also in that transition uh from a concern about existence to a thinker that now we need to perhaps modulate these things. Exactly. Like these kind of conversations and decisions is way above my pay grade. But whatever little I understand just from a pure small citizen of a country, I could say they will benefit more if they open up and be friendly than they would benefit from the way that they're doing today. Like a large part of I'll tell you just anecdotal situation and anecdotal incidents large part of my friend circle of entrepreneurs, they have

started having their doubts about Israel. now and they were all were like very pro because the way relationship is growing and now all of a sudden they have nothing to do with it. They don't live in Iran, they don't live in Gulf countries, they don't live in US, they have they probably won't even do business in Israel but that sentiment if it's changing on a ground level that something needs to be fixed. Yeah, true. Even in in the US by all polling it's seen that the younger people are not uh are much more critical than the generation before exactly because a lot of them admired uh Israel and its achievements but what the younger generation is seeing is a rather harsh uh form of Israel uh which doesn't reflect its full but that's what it's seeing and therefore there is that allure of Israel has diminished compared to what it was. Exactly. Like I admire what they've done just like every entrepreneur would admire because there's so little and they have figured out a way to win maximum achievements, maximum Nobel prizes, maximum influence over the world, the money they like just just every story you read about them, it's incredible. Just the smallest story is which people over often overlook as well that they're a deserted land and they have they didn't have water and in just 10 years they converted into a land with excess water. So they not only do it for the world but themselves. True. And all of that charm is now reducing because of the other things that they're doing. I I agree with you absolutely on that. I mean uh but uh states uh have to uh all states are reccalibrating and I think this is the time for everybody to look at these things. But aren't we scared of China in some way? No, we I don't think we are scared of China. I think scared is not the right word to use. Okay. What's the right word to use? The right words to use is yes, we are cautious. Yes, we are calibrated. But calibration caution for a country which is handling another country about five times its size is not weakness. It's maybe but they blatantly bully us almost everywhere. And what have we succumbed to apart from this? We haven't succumbed to any of the things that you said. We haven't succumbed. No. What have Okay, they said this about one of our citizens. Okay. They keep causing us trouble. No, every now and then. What do what else do you need? Pardon? Like they we we import a lot from them rather than who is forcing us it's all Indians who find it cheaper they're importing and if you ask most businessmen they want to import more at the end of the day there's a trade deficit on a country level true now it can be citizen problem entrepreneurs problem government problem I don't know I'm just asking you a genuine thing because of let's say maybe economic interest are we scared because of economic interest. No, I again we see that China is in many ways for enemy enemy but in some areas we gain from them. What friend? What friendship? What? I don't mean friendship. I meant friend enemy is yes there can be let's not tag it. They're somewhere in the bin between that can be one but tagging them for enemy is also bad because but we are they're not clear enemies but they're not clear friends. They're not friends at all. So why friend? Right? Because there are many things that we gain from our engagement with China. Let me give you an example. So our we are producing a lot of pharma. But the raw material for the pharma comes from Yes. comes from China. So our exports are increasing because our imports from China are also increasing. That's number one. Again, if you want more solar panels, the cheapest photo voltage sales coming from China. Now, you can say that I don't want to buy for China. I will have costlier ones. That's cutting your nose for no reason. So, my point is that there will be in a multipolar world, there will be something that you gain from some country. We should isolate that and say okay, we gain here, we lose here. Yes, it has led to a trade deficit and we've calculated that yes we must stop the trade deficit so we will push for more uh exports but our challenge is that the things that they are making and the things we are making there are many complimentary things so they will not buy from us except if our quality improves

and that's where we have to work hard and China didn't become the big export juggernaut that it has without effort for the last 25 years we've just started on this path and so we must give ourselves time and space to do it. Again it's like all the time we are judging ourselves in one point in history and one point in history is good to understand okay this is where we are but are we on the path towards trying to do better? Yes. Have we succeeded always? No. But that's the nature of the game. We will succeed in some. We may not succeed in some. And there is if you gain anybody who succeeds 80% in his life is considered a big success. So if a country is doing that much and getting about 80% better than where it was, I think it's a fair thing to say that the country is also doing well. Fair. But let's put trade, economics, all of these things aside. Do you think China's influence over our neighborhood countries, they have done way better job and we have lost there? It's true that China has become a major player in our neighborhood. Um, but it's not only our neighborhood. That is our problem. But it's not only our China is the largest trade partner with maybe 140 countries. Fair. We care about our 56. Fair. We care about our 56 and that's a fair thing to say. Um so our engagement economically we cannot compete today with China because they have deeper pockets and we will not get into a race of giving more because the small country will play both of us and gain more. But how deep pockets do they have compared to us when they can actually deal with 140 countries or 150 countries? We can't even deal with five. No, I think it's not fair to say say that because we you are saying those five were the ones who matter for us and that's a fair thing. So we should actually invest most of our energies in the five because that's a fair thing. Whoever wins neighborhood probably has a fair shot of winning the world. Agreed because or I can put it reverse that without winning the neighborhood you cannot win the world. That's a fair uh thing to put. uh so the issue is that it need not always play like this. So look at Cuba and USA. It's now 70 plus years they have a animosity. Doesn't stop USA from becoming the supreme power in the world. Uh but leave that aside. It's there's Mexico, there's Canada, there's true but Canada, sorry, Mexico's relationship with the USA has not always been good. They've had major major challenges not even now but even before that but influence and trade relationship have been have been over the last 20 years before that they also had a problem. So I I take your point that China has disproportionately invested in our neighborhood compared to us. So the only way we can address them is a challenge that we have to tie them up more with our structure. So there were times when we were giving large number of scholarships to study. Now we have a challenge that ask younger people want to study more. So the opportunities of a growing country means that you will not be able to compete with a country which is five times the economy. It's about five times I think. So our our uh thing is that where we have advantage we will try and gain and slowly we will plus we have a cultural advantage which China doesn't have but sometimes anomalous situations do rise like in Bangladesh the relationship was flourishing until there was a internal uh dislocation in that country. Now it'll take time for us to set it uh uh back. Sri Lanka we are doing now much better than what it was because we've invested a lot now in Sri Lanka. Bhutan we've always had a very good relationship. Uh in fact Bhutan much of electricity in Delhi comes from hydroelectric power which we have invested in Bhutan. Um we have challenge with Pakistan so leave Pakistan out. I will not get into that. That's be discounted as Cuba. Fair enough. But a larger one. A larger one. Um um so if you look at it, Nepal u Nepal the challenge is that many of their elites, we have seen what has been the same elites which had a challenge with India have been uh creating problems for themselves internally. We hope that with a new leader who is more representative of the Nepali people the engagement is more because he also comes from what we call Mades which is the area which is similar to our

part of uh Uttar Pradesh, Bihar etc and all he speaks etc and all. So our hope is that they are more they will be more understanding because previously it was the people of the Kathmandu valley who were dominant. So Nepal is a work in progress. But Nepal recently he issued a statement he wants greater Nepal. Everybody's all of a sudden out of somebody wants greater China, somebody wants greater Bangladesh, somebody wants greater Nepal. What is this happening? Why is everyone coming and just greater greater Pakistan? Nobody listens but they also want something greater like aspiration. Why is every neighborhood all of a sudden has started saying this and India made it a made it a thing that we can be silent let them say no I don't think we say that but I think what we say is that there are other ways there are other ways to tackle this so one way is that we just immediately say but you're saying that so you were saying that you're not saying with USA we are scared or something with China now are you telling me that we are scared of Nepal obviously not that's what I'm saying like don't you think that Because we because we don't say some anything to even smaller countries in front of the world, it puts us in a bad position. No, I think in a weaker position rather. So strength is not determined by the volume of um absolutely not. So I'm asking what would strength look like. So because from the optics it doesn't look like strength. No, it so from economic standpoint yes it looks like strength. So the thing is that they will make those statements and we have seen behind closed doors they say something else. So here's your choice. You can slap them on the wrist or you can say okay now it's done. Let's get down to business. And we've chosen the latter half. Even with Bangladesh you saw that they said they will not play cricket in India this that etc. The new government has come. they send their national security adviser to quietly talk with us. So those countries understand but they will always be always be in a neighboring country. There will always be a segment of population which wants to use or misuse or abuse this and say oh the big brother is worrying and this is the challenge of all big countries whether it's India, China or uh USA you will see that in the neighborhood there will be some elements of this. So there's US also made a statement about China and India at the in the same line. They said we won't make same mistake with India that we made with China. What do they mean by it? So from a diplomatic point of view tell me in easy language. So it's not unusual for countries to realize that rising powers could be a challenge for them. M so they saw that basically they're acknowledging that we made a mistake with China that we allowed them to be a developing country and therefore we gave them the benefits of trade which they have now used and grown in such a exponential manner that they are a challenge for us that's their experience with China so their fear is that other countries also may do this but I think that is a US style of communication which thinks that they gave anybody anything. Nobody gives anything to anybody unless there is in their mutual interest. So they thought China is a big market. Let us do this. Let's give them let's get into the market. So they did what they did. Similar with India. India will rise irrespective of whether US says or China says or China likes or India likes. The curve is not going to change. It will be a little bit up and down. That's understandable. You can push it a little below. You can push it up or something. But the natural growth of a country is its own. So let's look at our own growth. These are rhetoric and they can do what they want or say what they want. And best this time China had a good policy for many years. Their thinking was b your time, hide your talent. We are exactly in that space. B our time. Wait for the opportunate moment and do our things what we want. Keep our head down and let's focus on strengthening ourself. The rest will take care of yourself. Foreign policy. The best foreign policy is 8% growth. But you can't like we can't get into economics because it's another it'll open a different thread. 8% growth. there are insane number of factors etc etc etc like we can't we can't we should not enter that arena it'll take

me five more hours to that right it's it's a topic of interest but coming back to how do you interpret this warning no do you even interpret this as warning so first of all um that it has a thread of truth is not disputable that no country which is on top wants others to rise But they are engaged with us because they see us as a possible partner in many things where they want to balance out other equation. So he may have said it may have said it crudely may have said it imprudently but we understand that very well that our rise is not going to be something which everybody will support in every instance. We have seen that in their actions also. So it's it's not it's not something he's given us some new thing. This is a thinking that all people who are engaged with countries understand to the extent that they can work with us they'll work to the extent they cannot they will not and I would think that the American thinking still is that India's rise is in the interest of the US because they see it as a balancing factor in this part of the world. Mhm. Tell me as a when you were in when you were a diplomat, you were in the ministry, you were here everywhere serving a country in other nations and in India as well sometimes. Do you genuinely hate media because they they create more chaos beyond? Okay. Some do you think that media actually sometimes make things worse? some strategic leverages you lose because if media ruckers and you have to instantly give answer to the citizens inside it's true that sometimes diplomacy is best done beyond behind closed doors because the nature of that engagement sometimes it is always better so for example um very um delicate negotiations whether with the US or the nuclear deal or with China or or with Pakistan in the past. It's best because emotions should be kept out of hard uh way of engagement and it as a democracy we will always bring it out but open channels need not be the best way of arriving at solutions in some cases. In some cases, yes, it is. But it's also a fact that sometimes the media helps us. Uh, and I can mention some cases where um when the media was making a noise, we explained saying that look, you are asking for this, but it's not possible for us at all. Look at what our media is doing. So, it works both ways. And as a democracy, this is a small little challenge that we have to accept as a because it also helps us. But shouldn't we work together in order to actually win narrative war against the world like Indian diplomats, Indian media, Indian government, everybody should like work together in order to make sure that we are not showing that we are divided inside the country. We actually show strength as whole and be like hey it's against the world. We may fight and our own thing. Let us fight. Let us fight for the truth. let us fight for the rights and the wrongs but in front of the world we should together partner and be like we are the national assets and us against the world I agree if that's what we should aspire for um so there was a journalist who once told me a senior editor he said diplomats and journalists may be siblings but we are step siblings okay and his argument was that on many issues we may be together but on some I'm going to agree and there was a actually another journalist who once told me and I don't know whether it's true but this is the Hindi phrase she used that the horse can't become too friendly with the grass otherwise it can't eat anything it'll starve. So if that's the mindset it's going to be some areas that you will always diverge like step siblings you may be siblings etc. But I think the time has come now because India's performance is outpacing the perception of India. Yeah. And see just an example if I give you look at the UPI everybody is so fascinated that you know you can spend 100 rupees I don't remember when I last spent 100 rupees it's all through digital everybody comes and says oh this is a country but the perception is oh Indians are this etc and all so our performance has outstripped our perception and it's time for us to work together to enhance the perceptions and that can not come by government alone. Government is an important player but it's not the only player. Yeah. Uh and globally globally governments have depended on the media. Look at the BBC. It's funded from the

British foreign office. There are other uh channels or which have gone global. Al Jazzer was started with the seed money or huge fund fromQatar. It's today a global channel. So it's time for us to look at creative ways in which we can work because the world is as much about narrative as it's about reality. True. Perception is as important as is reality. And it's important for us to work at least on a common minimum issues. that okay on these they will be on domestic issues you may want to do what you want and that's a fair fair game there but on global issues it's time to encourage creative thinking it's also time for the government to start opening up and give data information which is e which can be easily absorbed and used. So both ways I think this is now the time because it can be a factor and a big factor for improvement very rapidly. True. I was sitting with few on business owners, entrepreneurs and world leaders a while ago and somebody made a loose comment and said that uh they were there telecom giants sitting. Okay. So somebody was very well active in South Africa, Morocco, bunch of other places. one of the largest players and then there was other person who was in like Pakistan and Bangladesh and Turkey and like places like these right so one one business owner he said that he just puted India Pakistan Bangladesh one window in one blanket and they they said that yeah we don't look at these markets because we don't know about financial inclusion financial transparency is not there I don't know how to do collections etc etc and just put it all there and so till that point I was also of a belief that enough of one UPI we have done now not everybody can talk just talk about UPI UPI UPI in the country right we need to talk about other innovations as well but that day I realized like a large part of the world still doesn't know about our UPI success they still put us in the same blanket as these other very less developed nations and They consider that we all are in the same and they they called like somebody called India highly cash economy and you don't know what money will come what will not come it's very difficult to me that's what's fascinating and before I could enter and say something a large player from Pakistan and Bangladesh he said that India is a very different market because Bangladesh and Pakistan he asked just he just said one thing okay which is like ask any Indian telecom player they'll tell you ask them the percentage of recharges which happen through cash or through UPI or through credit card and they'll tell you the difference between 10 years ago and today right huge ask any telecom player in Pakistan and Bangladesh what is the percentage of online transactions and this and then you would get to know that 90 95% of their economy still dependent True like in today's world India make nobody can believe that you have to go to a shop give money to get recharge done no matter how influential you are like that is so we have leapfrogged the financial inclusion part we have just killed that part and you know all these global businesses like the American ones Spotify your uh YouTube Netflix you know they They don't consider Pakistan, Bangladesh as big market. You know why? Because they don't have credit cards to even pay for their subscription. There are no debit card, credit card. There's no system. So UPI has really killed it. So to your point, in our country, we talk enough of UPI. But in the world, we still need to go out and talk about it because that's our export. So that was the first part, right? And the Oh, I got deviated because I got so excited. The other part was about the journalist thing. I was speaking to one journalist and I told them that hey you know what why are you always negative like why as a journalist you're always negative and as an Indian who is now traveling all around the world. I want to show the good sides of my country. I want to show the strength of my country so that I can drive better narrative. If I can build better friendships, I can probably through some videos, some podcast, some conversation, people start thinking that it's good to invest in India. So I want to drive more money from the world to our country and I want to show the strength of a country that it's no more the country of snake charmers which true

you know few people still believe in. So I want to change that. So I don't want to go there and talk about how how we are fighting and what we are doing and you know just don't be ne like there are times where we have to be negative and talk about realities of country but not every day and the journalist said something very nice he said you know Raj you and me we both are working towards the same goal you want to highlight the strengths of our country to the world to drive investment we want to highlight the problems of our country to the current people who are leading it so that they can fix it so that the more investments come and I I like that point. It was a fair thing to say a very fair thing to say. He's like as a journalist my responsibility is yes there are thousands of kilometers road getting developed every day getting constructed every day but there's one pothole which I care about fix that no I I think so you can talk about thousands of kilometers of road I'll talk about potholes and I like that no as long as your heart is in the right place does not matter whichever way you come true true I agree that you know it's a if your goal is the same. You can reach it through positivity or framing it in a more uh in a manner which is more challenging to the government and if it improves them why not and both are not mutually exclusive. Yeah. I think there will be and always there has to be that otherwise you're not a democracy. True. True. Tell me very important thing right which is about the international bodies don't you think they're completely useless today I want to elaborate this question right with stating some facts UN was created to prevent wars United Nations were created for that we've had Korea after that we have Iraq we have Iran we have Russia We have so many more. I can keep counting counting. The wars keep happening. The Gaza thing happened like just and right now it's going on short time. Right. World Trade Organization was created for free trade of the world. We having the biggest trade war of the world right now as we speak at this moment. Right? IMF was created to stabilize economies which are falling. They have given funds to Pakistan 24 times their economy still in trenches. So any global global body that we speak of today, they're all essentially flip failures like nothing has happened. So there is a saying that the UN was not created for mankind to heaven. Mhm. It was created with the hope that it will ensure that it doesn't descend into hell. So it's a low barrier that international bodies are trying to fulfill. But let's take some of the things that you said and let's examine that. So let's take peace and security where you said which is the most visible right now. So the peace and security architecture of the human has a design flaw and that is not by chance that the design flaw that is purely by choice that the design flaw was created which is that if there are any of the five permanent members involved the UN cannot do anything because that's how the veto is there so it cannot do any of the five members members or its very close ally cannot do. Therefore, by definition, it was only entrusted with the responsibility of second degree, third degree peace and security issues. But doesn't that mean you are giving power to five bullies and be like you can do whatever you want to? Agreed. So the logic that's absolutely that's our interpretation. Their interpretation is different. is saying that these are the only five who can lead to a world war in 1945. So their argument is if you push any of them into a corner, it will be a world war. And their goal was to ensure that a war like cataclysmic war like the World War II or World War I should not happen. So their argument is that it hasn't happened. Yes, secondderee wars are there also wars where one of the big paths is violating laws and doing it are happening but there has not been a clash among those five directly. Okay. You said one of the five members Russia is in always trouble and they are causing right but Russia has not fought directly with the US. But you said any war concerning these five people will not be fought. No. Will be fought but it cannot handle by the architecture of the UN. But so it will not deal with those. But US directly waged war which was an economic war by implicating implementing sanctions over Russia. Right. Yes.

But that's not a uh again that's not a peace and security issue. It's a economic what does world war look like like no I don't think anymore there is going to be a scene where two world economies are going to be going to send their foot on soldiers in some territory and going to fight it with each other right it's not going to happen in today's world it's going to be done through trade economy influencing other countries neighborhoods by attacking bombardingly by using advanced weapons by sending drones by doing cyber attack putting economic sanctions all of that is happening no so it's not happening with each other so where has US or Russia send drones against each other where economic sanctions happen pardon economic sanctions happen yes but again it's not economic sanctions also if you look at it the US and China have been very careful they make the noise they draw back every time so I'm not I Wish what you say is true that the cataclysmic scenario you said will not happen doesn't happen. I wish you are true but do you think it'll happen? You never know. What do you think? No. I I hope that they should not happen but never say never. What's your guess? Will it ever happen? No. I am as we're alive like will it happen? As a diplomat I will never say no to anything. I'm not saying which which which power fights who. No, don't say that. But do you think the way we are heading? So, so the thinking possibility of so the thinking is that the nearest the world situation now if you look in history and if you try to learn from history the nearest the world situation now is when it was between the two world wars that there was instability there were use of economic tools there were use of proxies there were one country eating up another country etc and all this is the most tumultous period since between the two wars. So you draw your own conclusion if you go logically maybe there is danger but maybe there is too much of interdependence it may not happen also. So let's hope for the latter not for the former but the situation clearly is the worst it has been since World War II. You saw China also put their ships around Taiwan. Yes, I I I read that uh also and that they have never said that they have not given up that goal ever. It's only a matter of time. One year left. The clock ticking. I don't know one year or not. Yes. But it could. But let's be clear that that's been their long-term goal. That's been an issue that they are pursuing and that is a legacy defining moment for a lot of Chinese leaders. So it's something that we have to be prepared for or plan for. But coming back to the I interrupted you. I'm sorry for the UN thing. Right. So I I told you that from the peace and security, the issue was not to get heaven that there will be peace on earth. No, the issue was that there will not be a confederation like World War II where both the thing now proxies proxy wars can proxy wars have been happening before even during cold war Angola war or Mozambique war or something there have been many proxy after you this no this is also in the 70s it's happened even during the cold war it has happened but it's become worse now uh and because the lethality of weapons has increased But if you don't have it, let's take it. Is it the world better off without having it or having something to deal with low-level conflicts? But does it ever like has it ever happened that some issue they have solved? Yes, there are many issues. The the ones that come into light, it looks like they've been effectively useless. No, the ones that have I'm sorry to use harsh words, but that's what the world is saying. Yes, it's a thing to say that if you but if you look at the history there have been so let's let's move India there have been 80 countries who have decolonized after the UN declaration of decolonization. So have they promoted a norm which led to decolonization? So never in the history of mankind have there been so many what we call nation states before they were empires. The British Empire, the Russian Empire, Chinese, whatever else etc. Indian Empire etc. But independent states of this number have happened only after World War II. So they set up a norm. So in a normative sense they helped in doing but but there are many other things that the UN does other than peace and security. So let's

take humanitarian assistance. I mean today there are about 25 million refugees in different countries. Those countries don't have the capacities to deal with it. It is UN bodies like the UN high commissioner for refugees doing. There are humanitarian bodies who are helping out uh and channelizing. Even when we were sending assistance to Afghanistan, we worked with what's called the World Food Program because we couldn't send to Afghanistan directly. Pakistan was not allowing us. So we sent through a uh through Iran. Biscuits were sent for students in this um medical equipment is sent. So there are a lot of things which don't catch the eye which the UN uh and its bodies are done are doing and whenever you have a challenge you say let's go. So for example with Iran everybody doesn't say you US should check whether Iran has nuclear weapons or not they say go to the international atomic energy agency. So there are some agencies there are some bodies which are doing they do it quietly and we need not because they are not in the news doesn't mean that they don't exist they work and they successfully are able to stop us from descending to hell interesting so UN is if I have to sum it up in simple words anything which which concerns the top five are their friends are their ends it will not no laws no laws are followed like nothing is followed because we have seen that happen the big bullies the big friends the whatever superpowers etc you want to call them you everything else they'll be they'll try and address those control okay so you essentially answered my next question also because I was going to ask you that we've been trying to become permanent members in so many years and China has been blocking there as well so why do we need to become a permanent member because of this. The moment we become permanent member then our interest also will concern the world then they will not touch us also will it happen so permanent membership so let me put it in two ways one is for an aspirational country which it has to set goals and it's a good aspirational goal to say I want to be on a table which decides because in diplomacy there is a thinking if you're not on the table you're on the menu card and we are too big now for anybody to digest on the menu. So we think that we are ready for the next level. So that's the aspiration. Whether that happens or not I can't answer because international organizations don't change easily. But that said then they become redundant. So they have a choice. Either they will accommodate India in some manner or they will become redundant. It's their call. As for us, whether we get there or otherwise, we will still have an increasing role to play. And we are not those who want to overthrow the established order. We are saying reform the order. We are not saying revolt against the order. We saying reform the order because by any our view is that by any matrix you put we should be there and you cannot take decisions for us. So for example climate you cannot take a decision for India when we have 1.6 6 million people economics you cannot take a decision similarly peace and security because it affects us and large number so I think as a goal it's the right thing to say it's the right thing to do whether it'll be achieved or not if it doesn't achieve it doesn't stop India's rise if we get it there will be greater stability and we protect our interests in the future and that's why you're doing it tell me one uh one country who has been looking after India's interest who a friend of ours just from purely interest point of view over the years they have again and again consistently supported India's interest so I it's a difficult call to take because each country I can find out one or two places where they looked after their interests net net I would think is Um for various reasons it would be Russia. Okay. And who's been the most dangerous and annoying person for us? Leave Pakistan. No. Clearly China. Clearly China is a major challenge for us. Both as our model and their model are competing competitors as our growth. They do not want anybody else in Asia. M um they see India as a big civilizational state that can rise and which may impede their uh domination. So for variety of reasons, China clearly is our

longerterm issue and we need to handle it with deafness today. We can't take them on directly. So therefore it's best to work out a via media. down the line there will be challenges and I think we need to just get ready that unlike the US before China sees India's rise as a challenge too and our goal is to ensure that we both have to rise we have no bother about their rising but they cannot impede our rise and that's our big challenge if there's one foreign policy challenge it is to ensure that our growth is not impeded by can true and China also sees us as threat. I was reading an article which is fun to read that everybody talks about economic challenges how India is growing population young population we have the world has announced China plus one we have cheap labor effective labor bunch of these things which are from a strategic economic point of view we have an upper hand and that's why we are keep we'll keep growing right China has one more threat from India which is the power of culture There is no other civilization apart from India which can actually compete with a Chinese ancient wisdom or ancient culture or civilization. So everything that they want to become they want to make soft power uh you know everything that they want their their culture or their food or their things to be a part of soft power all around the world India can challenge that true so that's why they have apart from economics they have this one big major fear as well because if we end up winning the soft power game economic power will be much easier to win And China clearly sees us that our rise is not in their interest. This they have concluded and therefore all the other problems are only subsets of that bigger goal that they have set for and we acknowledge that we have that challenge and so for the present we have to be navigating the field and therefore we will be sometimes very friendly with some other countries. We will work out via media with China and it's not a contradiction because what we are looking at is our rise and that's the primary goal. If it is facilitated by all these contradictions it's fine. Okay. Tell me one thing which is what do you think in last just last 10 years okay one decade what has been the best decision by India and what have been what has been the worst so the best decision is um I clearly feel that financial inclusion is a gamecher okay uh because It brings into one plate many things. It brings into it financial inclusion. It brings into it economic inclusion. It shows that technology Indians are not averse to adopting technology. U multiple things. So I I think by far it is the best decision in the last decade. The one which perhaps we should try and the worst. Let me think for a time. And this need not be foreign policy. You're saying anything. Yeah, the worst I think is the difficulties we are facing um in our own country regarding and it's a global phenomenon of polarization of u on anything anything the one party says the other party is opposed to it and it's not conducive to growth because you'll get stagnant like the US is now anything the Democrats say the Republicans do the Republicans come and the Democrats pull it down. So what has happened is that we are not judging issues on their merit. We are taking it saying that oh it cannot be passed because the opposition is there or somebody else is opposing and if you use that you'll find there are several decisions which we have delayed. So for example this um uh women uh uh certain amount of reservation for women I think we've unduly delayed it because in my view having seen the young people when India can harness their women I think we become a superpower. It's clear to me that I see these young women who are so good and so diligent and so working. It's just that we are not able to harness them. After some time they either flag off or move out etc. If they continue in the labor force, it's nothing can stop us if we because the men will do for themselves because this is a tradition. the women if we get in to our labor force if we harness their power and delaying that for whatever reason is not something that is in India's interest but I can understand the reason because you know many times we've tried some things it didn't work like the farm laws it didn't work you take it back so the policy of the government is let's do

step by step and that's perhaps the situation demands that but it could easily There was no need to have a diversion in this. You could work it out because I think women's empowerment and equality is the way for India's very rapid it'll open up many channels. True. True. What do you think is India's biggest diplomatic strength today and what is India's biggest diplomatic weakness today? So India's biggest diplomatic strength is uh access uh access to every country. Um it comes from variety of reasons. One is because India's size but also we have nurtured those relationship um at the highest level and at different levels and stability has provided that that you have a consistent head of state etc. So it has given you a strategic asset where you can pick up the phone and talk. There is no country where we can even though some criticize saying oh you supported them and you supported but you can see even in the present crisis you're able to engage with all sides. So I think India's biggest strength is that we have access now to key decision makers globally. Uh and that access can be turned into leverage if you do some things correctly. You'll get some things right, something may not be right. But access is our biggest strength, biggest weakness. biggest weakness is that um given the our economic needs, we have become vulnerable in a host of things and that allows countries to leverage us and it redowns on the government. Somebody will say he's fallen, he's now supporting this and that. If we had less vulnerabilities, we would be in a better situation. So or we would have used our so our access today is being used to uh to at least reduce our vulnerabilities. Um that vulnerabilities have to be addressed and those are at home. So if we address those at home, we will gain international. Just the last question. I would actually make it more fill in the blank. Okay, this is fill in the blank. that one one specific thing that you see critiques on social media calling out which you believe is absolutely about India's policy that India is subservient to whichever country this there is no truth in that belief of subservience Because explain you you think a lot of people are calling out that India is just following orders of US and we are uh just like let's say a puppet and whenever the US says something we don't say anything and we just follow them blatantly is absolutely Yes. this it's because look at our record um I can give you numerous instances where we have told no but in polite terms or told them that it's not possible and we won't do it but we haven't gone out and spoken out loudly about it because we don't think that's in our uh u it's in our interest right now so this belief that India will always be pro- US it will be a sub altern of the US this is entirely false it's a narrative that wants doesn't want to move as Abduladada it's a narrative which thinks that we have no agency independently sometimes we arrive at the same conclusion through different ways and it could be in some ways yes in some ways we agree because it's in our interest and you will see increasingly as we go forward there will be cases where we will not be able to agree with the US because the US is overreaching and when you overreach even the best of your friends will find it difficult to go with you and then you will see clearly that no this is not happening so right now you are judging Indian decisions where the difference is a judgment call and that judgment call can be right or wrong but not because you subservient but because you think it is in your interest but as you go forward if the US continues its uh sort of overreach you will clearly see that despite our uh thing that's why we are trying to have leverage with Europe with Japan etc so that we have enough uh balance in our ties and where we can then start saying that no clearly or yes clearly and I think we just need to be patient in this and foreign policy is not something that happens overnight. Many of the decisions this government took are based on decisions which are from the previous government or the one before that. For example, the nuclear will the governments before that prime minister Manm Singh etc have worked on it. Similarly our nuclear deterrent it is something several governments have worked on it. So if I see in the sweep of history clearly

uh India will rise as a pole. Yeah. And if it rises as a poll there will be cases where we say no to everybody and we just have to live with it. The others will also have to live with it. By then we'll be too strong for people to say well too bad but that's what we'll be the third pole. Yes. We will be another pole. True. It's you know you what you're saying that we are not subservient to anyone. US government official Mr. Howard Lutnik he said it on some podcast in US where he said in this whole tariff war all India had to do was to make prime minister call prime minister Modi call Trump and everything would have been in some way but India didn't budge India didn't bow down and PM Modi didn't call and they let the officials talk and eventually India made sure that they come down to terms which is in interest with India as well. We didn't let we didn't let them crush us over the time and that to me is a sign of strength where somebody's on a winning streak thinks that he can get done anything and everything and in that time you usually it's very natural for you to believe that you'll be able to get everybody yeah like make make everyone bow down and we didn't. So that's another sign that their own official is saying that it means it has some substance to it. In fact, I was right. So I was a while ago and he said, you know, one thing that everybody in the US circle is talking about, he's a key influential person. So he would say that like everybody's talking about that India is a mountain. Everybody thought it's like a sand mountain. We'll crush it and walk over. But India today is a mountain which is not of a sand. So you have to make your way around it if you want to work. You can't just crush it and walk all over it. So you need to understand that India has strengthened itself a lot. No right because I think you know civilizationally it is against our nature to be a follower. I mean I remember forget about thing I remember myself that anybody somebody pushes me I will say no. M even if it's incorrect I may say later on yes but it's I think we are as a people maybe because it was colonization or whatever it's in our culture that we are not going to be camp followers this camp follower business is not for us. True. Uh and sure we are not leaders right now but we have the potential and that's why we are aiming. Okay. See we may reach in another 25 years 29 that's all right but we will reach and whether they like it or not they will just have to adjust to like people say whether you like it or not after some time a lot of Hindi udu all these Bengali words will come in English and the way the Indians speak English will be what English is that's it because just the numbers are just going to be so staggering so I I am confident that these ups and downs will you're confident the way world is thinking that we will grow we'll grow at that pace I I can't be certain but it will not dramatically alter the trajectory it can go sometimes more sometimes there will be this is bound to happen but I don't see a change in the trajectory and that's the thing that we are we should go on this trajectory for several more years then it becomes automatic you see we have been on this trajectory now and we need to go for another 10 15 years then autopilot. Yeah, we don't need to worry about it. Everything is even if you do too many mistakes it's all absorbed in like America does mistakes every 10 years it just adjusts and goes off. True. I I just love the fact genuinely whether it's government or citizens from the low level to the top level India has become a conversation at least on every table. This is also true. This this was not there before not at all. it earlier it was not there were only five big boys and they thought it's their club now the big boys think that there's another big boy building they clearly think they will not say openly etc but they will accommodate everybody knows it now India is part of every conversation I think it's a good start when I was looking about you and then I remembered there was a Swedish rapper Pewie Pew PewDiePie Pewdiepie yeah so this is 2016 2017 I think when I was in America At that time there was a big debate key will T-Series overtake PewDiePie Pewdiepie or not and there was like a song thing I also supported T-Ser Indian because the number of views etc. So that's what I was seeing that if people like you get 25

million viewers world will see 25 million and just the sheer weight it's like China today you may not like China but you cannot ignore it that's it so just the sheer weight of our presence will do it and I don't know when it'll come but the trajectory if we don't if we don't really spoil ourselves somewhere in the middle and I don't see it happening. It's a Yeah, it may happen. You may win by three wickets, you may win by nine wickets. A win is a win. Like they say a rising tide lifts all boats. Yeah. And so small boards, big boards, all of us have I have seen myself in my career how people used to treat us before and how people treated us in my last few years of diploma is totally different. I mean this I mean visibly I could I can say there was nothing when we were first 80s late 80s early '90s nobody bothered India they would say we know what you will say etc because they know we will criticize and all thank you so much thank you very much for taking all the time and for adjusting no it was pleasure to host you was amazing thank you so much for being here thank you for doing everything that you have done no no this very kind of you and all the best to you. It's nice to see young rising talents do very well and I just wanted to thank you for everything you are doing and so please keep doing whatever you're doing. All the best to you. Thank you. Hi, pleasure meeting you sir. Pleasure meeting you. Young people like you have to thrive. So the bar is high. You aspirational young India. I'm tired and retired. No one of the reasons why we are able to aspire big. No, you're one of them. That was very kind of you. Thank you so much for watching this episode till the end. Now you have to do three things. Number one, subscribe to this channel right now. The more you subscribe, the better the guess we will be able to get for you. Number two, please comment and let us know what did we do wrong and what did we do right because the more you give us feedback, the better we will be able to make episodes for you. And number three, please share this episode with at least one person because one conversation can change someone's entire life. I'll see you next time. Until then, keep figuring out